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3

TANTRISM “SEEN FROM THE EAST”

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An isolated feature of the incomplete picture of an ancient epoch, full of gaps as it may be, may not convey any meaning to us, but if we find it again at a later epoch just as a part of an organic whole, we can conclude its being a similar part of an organic whole at the ancient epoch, only perhaps in an earlier stage of development.

Hermann Oldenberg (1973, p. 43)

The original form of Hindu spirituality would have been a spirituality of “Spirit Beings”.

David Gordon White (2012, p. 165)

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1. Introduction

This chapter intends to raise the question as to whether the socio-religious movement we now call “Tantrism” may represent a wider Monsoon Asian areal phenomenon, with roots in a past that predates the earliest available textual data. It has been directly inspired by, and it engages with, three thought-provoking essays by anthropologist Robert Dentan on a common religious base in South and Southeast Asia (2002*a*, 2002*b*, this volume).² As a scholar trained in Sanskrit and Classical Indology focusing on the adoption of Indic religions across Southeast Asia, I intend to take up the challenge cast by Dentan, namely that “speculative reconstruction of Semai theological history... suggests that serious students of Hinduism, Buddhism, and Daoism, need to pay attention to the indigenous religions of Peninsular Malaysia” (2002*b*, p. 207).

I begin the discussion by surveying the historiographical parameters concerning the complex process of cultural and religious transfer between premodern South and Southeast Asia, and the origin of Tantrism. Next, I revisit the idea, advanced by early twentieth-century French scholarship, of a shared cultural matrix in Monsoon Asia, within which framework Dentan’s hypothesis may be situated. I then move to review Dentan’s main argument that a comparison of similar religious tropes found in the late Vedic tradition and in the oral lore of the Austroasiatic language-speaking ethnic group of the Semai in Peninsular Malaysia would suggest a common ancestry. By taking into account additional evidence from premodern and modern South Asian, Javano-Balinese, and Malay contexts, I suggest that many of the similarities detected by Dentan extend to the post-Vedic period, i.e. to Tantric Śaivism and Tantric Buddhism in the mediaeval or post-Gupta period (ca. 500–1300 CE).

My main thesis is that phenomena that are perceived by current scholarship as being either “Indic” or “local”/“indigenous” in nature were in fact already shaped by multi-directional and supra-local circulatory

² In choosing the title of this chapter, and with respect to its pivotal conceptual issues, I have also been inspired by the essays “India seen from the East: Indian and Indigenous Cults in Champa” by Paul Mus (1975 [1933]) and “Construction Sacrifice in India ‘Seen from the East’” by Roy Jordaan and Robert Wessing (1999).

dynamics; therefore, a perspective transcending the current paradigm is required to make sense of their genesis and transfer over a long period of time. Because of the complexity of the issues at stake here, and the vastness of this field of enquiry, my investigation is preliminary; rather than answering all the pressing questions, it only intends to provoke discussion and point at possible directions for future study.

2. Indic Religions and Premodern Dynamics of Globalization

Having discussed some uncanny similarities between the Vedic “outsider God” Rudra and Nkuu’, the “Dark Lord” of the Semai, Dentan (2002b, pp. 219–20) suggests that the two figures,

rather than being respectively ancestor and descendent, are cousins, developments of a primordial religion that stretched at least from eastern India to southern China.... If students of Hinduism and Buddhism want to familiarize themselves with pre-Aryan religion, it might be useful for them to spend some time with the indigenous religions of Malaysia, which, rather than being ‘primitive’ or ‘bizarre’, may represent a parallel development from a common base; and be closer to that base than theologies elaborated by generations of professional theologians.

The key hypothesis revisited by Dentan, i.e. that premodern Monsoon Asia shared a common ancestral religious matrix, was advanced by the French savants Jean Przyluski, Sylvain Lévi and Paul Mus in the first half of the twentieth century. This wider-ranging Monsoon Asia areal approach appears to have lost ground in the second half of the century to the advantage of more context-specific regional approaches to the study of premodern cultural and religious phenomena across South and Southeast Asia, which focus on regions and/or nation-states, and emphasize local genius and cultural specificity. Whenever supra-local (“cosmopolitan”) cultural phenomena are taken into account, they have been nearly always described through the lens of the Indic and Sanskritic high culture—as opposed to a (by definition) “local” or indigenous (i.e. *deśi*) culture. With respect to the religious history of the Indian Subcontinent, this tendency has resulted in a widespread scholarly opinion regarding Classical Hinduism, and Tantrism, as mainly orthogenetic

developments from a Vedic and Brahmanical matrix, enriched by influences from local or regional cults of South Asia. Indic religions of Southeast Asia are usually described in terms of either local religions featuring varying degrees of Indic influences, or Indic religions featuring varying degrees of local adaptation. The problem of directionality and historical influence, hence the question of Southeast Asian agency in the spread of ideas and practices to South Asia, has rarely—if ever—been raised; furthermore, Southeast Asia has been usually regarded as peripheral—at most a crossroads, or passive receiver, of Indic cults.

According to Dentan, older—yet still prevalent—views regarding Hinduism (and Śaivism) as a pot-pourri of beliefs and practices accumulated from all periods of South (and Southeast) Asian history need to be revisited. Such views (see, for example, Cady 1964, pp. 36–37) maintained that Śaivism, in both South and Southeast Asia, absorbed in a selective way “primitive cults of fertility” and of the Mother, Sun worship, etc., embedding (autochthonous) spirit-cults and what are often called “shamanic” practices. Dentan’s study, on the other hand, “fleshes out and modifies the old theory that Indian ideology, particularly Śaivism, found an ‘easy accommodation’ with Southeast Asian religions because of syncretic Hindu praxis back in India” (2002*a*, p. 157). Dentan rather suggests a contrary—yet multi-faceted—process, i.e. one that involved

the slow internal differentiation of an unformalized and unnamed aboriginal religion which spread throughout south and southeast Asia; its resultant differentiation into diverse forms in India and... the mountainous interior of Peninsular Malaysia; and a subsequent convergence in the first millenium AD as Indian traders, princes and missionaries introduced their Hindu and Buddhist modifications of the original religions into the area. (ibid.).

Dentan (ibid., p. 155) challenges his readers with a series of questions, then offers a preliminary answer:

What kinds of similarities were there between the Indian Motherland and the peoples of Malaysia? What ways did knowledge flow? Perhaps, in the figure of the monstrous God of Beasts, who taught humans magic, we moderns can discern the foreshadow of globalization.

Discussions of premodern dynamics of globalization in the wide geographical area spanning from Northwestern India to insular Southeast Asia can be subsumed under the abundant literature on “Indianization”, which has been briefly surveyed in the introduction to this volume. Here suffices it to point out that religious history has often been left out of the picture. This is the case, for instance, of the compelling hypothesis on a “Sanskrit Cosmopolis” elaborated by Sheldon Pollock (1996, 2006), which covers the expression of aesthetics of politics through first Sanskrit and then cosmopolitan vernaculars, yet glosses over the most widespread and long-lasting of all religions spread over South and Southeast Asia in the mediaeval period: Śaivism. Alexis Sanderson (2009) has produced a masterful study on what he has termed the “Śaiva age”, the geographical extent of which largely coincides with that of Pollock’s Sanskrit Cosmopolis. Sanderson presents detailed text-historical evidence on the rise and dominance of this religion in the Indian Subcontinent and “peripheral” areas, such as Southeast Asia, in the mediaeval period; however—and understandably so, given the paucity of evidence—Sanderson does not adequately address the question of its genesis (as we shall see, this question may be connected with the predominance of Śaivism throughout Monsoon Asia, namely its penetration into all stratas of societies and not just among the elites). Ronald Davidson (2002) and Geoffrey Samuel (2008) have delved into the question of the genesis of Tantric Buddhism and Tantric Śaivism, discussing social dynamics in which “subaltern/marginal” or “foreign/indigenous” agents and milieux played a role, yet have only marginally taken into account Southeast Asia. In an excellent study on what he calls a “Demonological cosmopolis”, David White (2012) investigates the supra-local nature of Tantric phenomena attested over much of Asia; “looking west”, he hypothesizes an Iranian/Central Asian origin for several widespread Tantric tropes. In this light, an evaluation of Dentan’s theories against the background of recent developments in the fields of Indology and Tantric studies seems now in order.

3. The Quest for Origins: History (and Geography) of Tantrism

Before reviewing Dentan's hypothesis about a possible shared religious matrix, I would like to define my main subject of enquiry, i.e. "Tantrism", and discuss its genesis in its (posited) homeland, namely the Indian Subcontinent. Tantrism is a complex term, used both emically (*tantra*, *tantrasāstra*, and the adj. *tāntrika*) and etically as a catch-all category to refer to an equally complex socio-religious phenomenon. According to Gavin Flood's definition (2006, p. 9), "The term *tantra* as a noun is a term of self-description that refers to specific texts of revelation and is also a term designating a system of revealed teaching that leads to liberation and power". The phenomenon of Tantrism has been a vehicle for cultural transfer, and indeed it encompasses disparate beliefs and practices, soteriological and ritual systems, and their related cultural manifestations across much of South, Central, Southeast, and East Asia.

These phenomena or orientations, occurring across religious divides (i.e. Śaiva, Buddhist, Vaiṣṇava, and even Jaina) in both elite and lay milieux, featured elements of initiation and secrecy; empowerment and divinization with the assistance of psycho-physical techniques and/or magico-ritual procedures (e.g. mantras, *yantras*, and *maṇḍalas*); transgression of social, sexual, and dietary norms; worship of wrathful deities; ritual violence; possession and exorcism; and different genres of sacred performance. As argued by Urban (1999, p. 126),

'Tantra' is not something that can be defined as a singular, unified category; rather, it can only be described by means of what J.Z. Smith calls a 'polythetic classification', in which 'large number of characteristics are possessed by a large number of class members'.

Although it is hardly possible to formulate a comprehensive working definition of the elusive "Tantric", I believe that on the basis of the ever-growing body of scholarship produced in the past three or so decades, and by applying a polythetic approach (see Landmann, this volume), it is legitimate to posit a complex, distinctive, and eminently cross-cultural phenomenon comprising several of the above features. This phenomenon

developed in its most distinctive forms around the first half of the first millennium CE, and eventually spread to many socio-cultural and religious milieux across Asia (and Monsoon Asia in particular).³

The vexed question concerning the (socio-)historical origin of Tantrism has dominated the scholarly debate since the inception of the academic study of Indian religions. Two general paradigms may be identified: heterogenetic vs. orthogenetic. The former, which is the earlier, envisages a non- or pre-Aryan origin of Tantrism (and especially its feminine-oriented currents, subsumed under the category of “Śāktism”), and “Classical” or “post-Vedic” Hinduism at large, by positing a contact between an imported (adstratal) Vedic religion and a pre-existing cultic substratum in the Indian Subcontinent.⁴ Various cultural and geographical origins of this pre-Aryan substratum have been proposed, i.e. Dravidian (Conze 1975, p. 178), Austric (including “Negrito” and Malayo-Polynesian),⁵ shamanic (whether Central Asian or not, see Eliade 1971 and Samuel 2005), Harappan (Basham 1954, p. 23, Bhattacharyya 1999, pp. 156–60), “folk” (Hardy 1983, p. 141), or

³ Not unreasonably, Urban (2003, p. 27) warns against the anachronistic projection of the abstract category of “Tantrism” onto premodern traditions, arguing that Tantrism is a modern construct that arose, like Hinduism, from the dialectical encounter between Indians and Western Orientalists. Yet, the existence of “Tantras” and distinctive discourses concerning them in the premodern period, both within and without South Asia, cannot be denied. Furthermore, the terms “Tantrism”/“Tantric” aptly capture the apparently common milieu of ritual practice characterizing both Śaivism and Buddhism (as well as other religious streams) in the mediaeval period.

⁴ An offshoot of this debate is, for instance, whether yoga developed within a Vedic milieu or as a result of the influx of non-Vedic (i.e. shamanic, or even Chinese/Daoist) psycho-physical practices (see Eliade 1971; Samuel 2008, p. 84).

⁵ For instance, S.K. Chatterjee (1965, p. 153) refers to “certain remarkable agreements between the cosmogony of the Polynesians and that of the Nāsadiya hymn in the Ṛg Veda (X.129)”, and to some astronomical ideas and terminology, e.g. the enumeration of the days by the phases of the moon, the “Austric” names for the two phases of the moon, the creation of the world from an egg, and Nāga-lore (see *ibid.*, pp. 149–67 for a wider discussion of Austro-Asiatic and Austronesian loan-words and cultural tropes). Some of these views are clearly the product of the nationalistic milieu of the Greater India Society, and have been long since discredited.

tribal ($\approx$ “local”, “autochthonous”, or “indigenous”).⁶ As a reaction to this trend of thought, an orthogenetic model has gained popularity in the past two or three decades, which regards Classical Hinduism on the one hand, and Tantrism on the other, as a direct development of Vedic religious ideology and Indo-Aryan (magico-)ritual praxis.⁷ Championing an orthogenetic model, Flood (2006, p. 14) offers the following synthesis:

There is much speculation about the origins of Tantrism. On the one hand the origins have been seen in an autochthonous spirituality or Shamanism that reaches back to pre-Aryan times in the subcontinent, yet textual historical evidence only dates from a more recent period. While certainly there are elements in tantric traditions that may well reach back into pre-history—particularly the use of skulls and the themes of death and possession*—we simply do not have sufficient evidence to speculate in this way. As Robert Mayer has shown, there is no evidence for a non-Aryan substratum for Tantrism, which must be understood as a predominantly Brahmanical, Sanskritic tradition with its roots in the Veda. In an important book on the origins of Indian civilisation, Sergent has argued that our main resources for understanding the past are linguistic

⁶ See, for example, van Gulik (1935, p. 4), Tucci (1949, p. 216), and Beane (1977, p. 37ff.). More recently, Vidya Dehejia (1986, p. 1) has argued that the Kaula Tantric tradition has “roots outside the fold of Brahmanical Hinduism” and “deep connections with tribal traditions” (of Orissa, Eastern India, etc.). For recent discussions of the “tribal hypothesis”, see Davidson (2002, pp. 211–14) and Samuel (2005, p. 410); cf. Urban 2011. White (2012, pp. 1s64–65) includes the “local or regional cults of *yakṣas*, *devatās*, *bhūtas*, and the like” in the substratal traditions that ought to be taken into account when reckoning the origins of and influences on “Tantric demonology—which is the foundation upon which all of the magnificent Tantric systems and hierarchies that Hindu Tantra specialists study are grounded”.

⁷ A “strong” orthogenetic model has been championed also by Biardeau and Heesterman, among others, while scholars like Dumont, Eliade and Olivelle, have advanced a “weak” orthogenetic model, which posits a process of “‘challenge and assimilation’ in which new models and approaches, not necessarily emerging from within the Vedic context, are confronted and incorporated more or less successfully” (Samuel 2008, p. 160). To Samuel, the “‘orthogenetic’ approach offers elegance and closure, but it lacks a certain degree of realism, especially given that the logic of Vedic thought and practice is such that new developments are regularly incorporated through the use of resources already present within the tradition”.

and archaeological. There is no early archaeological evidence for tantric traditions beyond the common era, and while there is textual evidence for a cremation ground asceticism as far back as the time of the Buddha, as well as tantric-like goddesses in the Veda, the specificity of the tantric revelation appears more recently in the history of South Asia.

In footnote (*), Flood adds that "There are spiritual practices, such as breathing techniques, in both East and West that may share a common heritage and probably reach back into prehistory" (referring to Eliade 1971, pp. 104–7 and La Barre 1974, pp. 404–6).

Urban (1999, p. 126) asserts that the history of Tantrism is impossible to write because of poverty of data at present, and that "the most we can say is that, although Dravidian or pre-Aryan origins may be possible, Tantric traditions have clear relations to the Vedic tradition as well". Along similar lines, White elaborates a synthesis between an orthogenetic and heterogenetic approach (2000, p. 18), contextualizing the historical origin of Tantrism as follows:

Tantra was an orthogenic development out of prior mainstream (but not necessarily elite) traditions, that nonetheless also drew on both foreign (adstratal) and popular (substratal) sources.

Brighenti (2009, pp. 63–64), while discussing the question of the origins of the mediaeval Śākta practices of human sacrifice, argues that

this process of cultural interaction, out of which the whole Tantric religious complex has originated, had as its vectors the 'people of the Veda' on the one hand, and people of disparate ethnic origins (Dravidian, Austro-Asiatic, Austronesian and Tibeto-Burman) on the other.... I regard the Śākta ritual to be the final outcome of a long process of cultural syncreticism through the development, contact, and combination of diverse ethnocultural streams.

Elaborating on the controversial issue of the origins of Rudra-Śiva, the "outsider god" of the Vedic pantheon, Peter Bisschop (2013) takes a cautious stance:

The question of Śiva's cultural background is one that has received much attention from scholars past and present.... A central issue at stake here

is whether Śiva stems from a vedic (Aryan) or a nonvedic (non-Aryan, Dravidian) background. The debate revolves around the question of whether the deity Rudra, thought to be Śiva's predecessor in the Vedas, is essentially an outsider or an insider to the vedic pantheon.... The issue of the true background of Rudra remains unresolved, but the complex nature of Śiva himself most probably points to a *complex cultural background in which both vedic and extra-vedic elements have played a role*. (emphasis mine)

The matter is still far from being settled, and chances are it never will. Yet, it is interesting to note that, in spite of the fact that so many blank spots remain, the “Indian” origin of Tantrism is hardly ever questioned, being taken for granted as an axiom by most scholars. Whenever “peripheral” areas such as Southeast Asia or the Himalayan region are worked into scholarly account, “India”—as if it was a monolithic and clearly defined entity!—is invariably seen as the cradle of “Indic” religious and cultural phenomena, and other areas as the “borrowers”. Yet, if one looks at the emic accounts, i.e. those found in the mediaeval Tantric texts from South Asia and Tibet, one notes a fascination for the “foreign” and the “exotic”. This fascination is articulated through the attribution of the origin of Tantric cults to either tribal milieux or peripheral, far away lands.⁸ Davidson's (2002) reflections on South Asian Esoteric or Tantric Buddhism (and related Hindu traditions) are instructive here. Davidson (*ibid.*, p. 226) notes that

the obscure words of coded language found in the *Hevajra-tantra* and elsewhere are often designated ‘foreign speech’ (*mleccha-bhāṣā*) or ‘the language of Oḍḍiyāna’.... ‘foreign’ in early medieval India did not simply

⁸ Several of the major Tantric seats were in regions at the “margins” of the Indic world, for example Kāmarūpa (Assam), Oḍḍiyāna (either Central Asia/the Northwestern part of the Indian Subcontinent, or South India), Śrīśailam (in a Southeastern Indian, prevalently tribal area); compare the Tibetan fascination with Shambhala, or the attribution of the origin of certain doctrines or schools to remote lands, such as Suvarṇadvīpa (Java or Sumatra, in the case of the Kālacakra system revealed to Atīṣa by Piṇḍo/Kaiki Śrīpāla) or Mahācīna (in the case of a transgressive form of Tārā). See White 2000, p. 18, and Samuel 2008, p. 84ff; for examples of Tantric teachers from tribal milieux, see Davidson 2002, p. 228.

designate 'extraterritorial'. As a term, it also applied to the plethora of tribal peoples found throughout the areas now known as Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Orissa, Gujarat, Konkana, Bengal, Assam, Kashmir, and Swat—precisely in all the strongholds of esoteric Buddhism.

A controversial point in the debate is the dichotomy between "Sanskritic" and "tribal"—a dichotomy that is also relevant to the present discussion of Dentan's hypothesis. In both South and Southeast Asian contexts, the problem of directionality and historical influence remains crucial. Having pointed out that "it is not easy to see how an orally based, hunter-gatherer culture is directly related to religious scriptures (tantras) that are generated in an agrarian society", Davidson (*ibid.*, p. 225) concludes that tribal peoples were aggressively Hinduized since the early mediaeval period, and this Hinduization included the appropriation of tribal deities, rituals, and cultic sites. In short, Davidson suggests that complex interactions between Tantric practitioners and members of indigenous communities were going on in South Asia, and speaks of a two-way process, which illuminates the phenomenon of cross-fertilization between Sanskritic and tribal religions. To him, these trajectories brought a strong "sense of affiliation" between Tantric Buddhist (or Śaiva) ascetics, generally labelled Siddhas, and the "peoples of the forest" (*ibid.*, p. 227).

Reasoning along similar lines, Samuel (2005) associates Tantra (especially in its Tibetan Buddhist variety) with what he calls "shamanism".⁹ Samuel defines Vajrayāna Buddhism as a "sophisticated version of Shamanism" (2005, p. 74), for elements of Vajrayāna ritual are

⁹ The caveat here is that Samuel (2005, p. 11) uses "shamanic" (and "shaman, shamanism") as analytic categories of mediumship that do not imply any historical association with the category of Siberian shamanism. To him, a shaman is a "shapeshifter, in the sense of someone who moves between different roles or *personae*"; "the symbolic entities used in shamanic procedures in many small-scale societies... could be seen as shared cultural resources facilitating these shifts and alterations, shifts which affected both mind and body, both the individual and their social group. Shamanic practitioners operate with these spirits or with analogous symbolic identities". I conform to this usage throughout my essay.

similar to certain practices of mediumship, which could partly account for its origins. Blaming a restrictive and typological fashion in which shamanism has often been treated, he encourages a more polythetic approach in the study of such practices as healing, exorcism, divination, and spirit mediumship involved in the transformation of consciousness. He suggests that the basic structure of Tantric (Vajrayāna) ritual can be found, besides in Sanskrit texts and their Tibetan translations, also “in the surviving traditions of Tantric practice of Japan, Bali and the Newar population of the Kathmandu valley”, thereby betraying an apparent Indian origin (p. 77). Samuel opens to the possibility that “siddha lineages include a number of figures that might be regarded as ‘tribal’ in origin”, and that “it is tempting to look to tribal populations as sources of the shamanic aspects of the Vajrayāna, since the tribal people of today certainly preserve elements of shamanic practice (Rahmann 1959)”, whose idiom however “does not seem particularly close to that of Vajrayāna shamanism” (p. 86). Urban, in his discussion of the rise of Tantra in Northeastern India (2011), notes that the situation “most likely involved a more subtle *interaction, negotiation, and mutual transformation* between brāhmaṇic and local non-Hindu traditions” (emphasis original),¹⁰ and that Śākta Tantra in Assam “is largely the result of a long, historical negotiation between Sanskritic traditions and the indigenous kings who patronised them, almost all of whom came from the non-Hindu tribes of the northeast hills” (p. 232).

Turning to a more historical endeavour, Samuel (2008, p. 343) senses a tension or opposition between Vedic-Brahmanical culture in the Northern Indian region of Kuru-Pāñcāla and the surrounding belt of cities and states in the Central Gangetic region and the Deccan.

¹⁰ Urban here follows “the lead of Wendy Doniger, who suggests that the development of Hinduism as a whole in South Asia was not simply a process of Sanskritisation, that is, the absorption of non-Hindu traditions into the brāhmaṇic system; rather, it also involved a process of ‘Deshification’, that is, the influence of local (*deshi*) and indigenous cultures on brāhmaṇic religion and the mutual interaction between Sanskritic and *deshi* traditions”. To both scholars, it would appear that these *deśi* traditions are “local” or autochthonous by definition, i.e. themselves not the result of supralocal dynamics.

Bringing in connections with other regions of India, Central Asia, and Southeast Asia, Samuel frames the question of origin not as the contrast between indigenous people and “Aryan invaders”, but rather in terms of a cultural opposition (i.e., a pastoralist warrior-chieftain culture vs. an agrarian culture having elements of the philosopher and the renunciate) between genetically mixed populations already speaking mostly Indo-Aryan languages.

The above-mentioned historical narrative reminds us of that advanced by Johannes Bronkhorst in his “Greater Magadha hypothesis”. Bronkhorst (2007) argues that Brahmanism did not constitute the background in which Buddhism arose, for while Brahmanism was the dominant ideology in the region centred on the Doab of the rivers Ganga and Yamuna, Buddhism arose in the region to the east of the confluence of these two rivers (“Greater Magadha”), which had a different culture and ideology. Vedic and early post-Vedic literature contains little information about the culture of its eastern neighbours, yet early Brahmanical literature contains sparse evidence, such as references to demonic “people from the east” constructing sepulchral mounds, whose later embodiments might be the Buddhist stūpas (Bronkhorst 2007, pp. 4–5). While Bronkhorst does not attempt to comprehensively unpack the historical, genetic, and sociolinguistic aspects of the Aryan/Brahmanical vs. Non-Aryan/non-Brahmanical divide, some promising findings by John Peterson suggest that an overlap may have existed between the cultural and linguistic (i.e., Munda/Austroasiatic vs. Indo-Aryan) boundary of “Greater Magadha”.¹¹

An issue that has been subject of much scholarly controversy, and that directly bears on the genesis and development of Classical Hinduism, Tantric Buddhism and Tantric Śaivism in South Asia, is that of a “pan-Indian religious substratum”. The idea of an early religious substratum was (re-)elaborated by David Seyfort Ruegg

¹¹ I thank John Peterson for having discussed his findings and their relation with Bronkhorst’s theory in a series of emails, and for having shared with me an unpublished paper (Peterson forthcoming). See also below, pp. 105–6.

(1964, 2008), who advocated a common cultic stock that would *ex hypothesi* form the common source from which both Śaiva and Bauddha Tantric traditions derived, and to which they ultimately owe their shared common elements. This “substratum model”, which is theoretically and historically neutral towards the problem of pre-Aryan or non-Aryan elements (ibid. 2008, pp. 41, 90),¹² has been criticized by Alexis Sanderson (1994, 2001), mainly on account of its being an abstract and unverifiable, i.e. purely inferred, concept or entity. Sanderson himself has advanced a paradigm that has been later labelled by his readers as a “borrowing model”. Sanderson’s research on Sanskrit primary sources of the Śaiva Mantramārga and the Bauddha Yogatantra has highlighted the divide between the two traditions, and justified the common elements on the grounds of a great deal of mutual influences, or even manifest plagiarism, occurring between both systems—but especially the incorporation of materials of the former (and arguably earlier) textual corpus into the latter.

A negative stance against the quest for origins has been taken by Christian Wedemeyer (2013), according to whom a “consistent appeal to origins would (and, in fact, practically does) make the study of Tantric Buddhism impossible” (p. 34). Championing an orthogenetic approach, Wedemeyer has criticized the “tribal hypothesis” by teasing out formal fallacies in the approach of Davidson and others. According to Wedemeyer, a notion that would characterize “much of contemporary thought about the origin of the Tantras” is

that—even after the ascendancy of the Vedic cultural model—primordial, pre-Āryan religious currents continued to be practiced among ‘marginal’ communities that included primitive groups such as India’s so-called ‘tribal’ population. (p. 21)

¹² Contrast Hardy (1983, p. 141), who explains a number of close similarities between the manifestations of “folk religion” in the northern and southern areas of the Indian Subcontinent “by postulating a very archaic and universally Indian form of popular religion of non-Āryan origin”.

Having criticized this view, Wedemeyer does not provide a truly compelling alternative either.¹³ He does not do full justice to the complexity of the issue at stake when he claims that militating against this view is the absence of "any literary evidence for these supposed traditions and their communities", and that the best evidence "that can be marshaled are vague and ambiguous traces such as busy Harrappan [sic] terra-cottas, sanguinary rites of tribal groups, or speculations on the non-Āryan elements in the secret tantric codes" (ibid., p. 197). Although Wedemeyer is right in stressing that tribals have in the past been too often naively perceived—in a Taylolean fashion—as bearers of a timeless, primordial, and "primitive" culture, it seems nonetheless unreasonable to rule out the fact that relatively isolated non-literate small-scale communities (such as the Semai of peninsular Malaysia) may have been more stable than others, and may thus have preserved distinctive, and remarkably resilient, cultural traits alongside foreign (i.e. Indic or Islamic) influences.

However useful they are to capture the elusive dynamics that shaped the South Asian religious discourse in the mediaeval period, all the above approaches do not fully address the question of their ultimate origin, nor explain why cross-fertilization seems to have taken place in such a productive manner—in spite of the caveat expressed by Davidson about the difficult-to-explain relation between orally-based hunter-gatherer cultures and religious scriptures produced in agrarian societies;¹⁴ at the same time, they limit their main scope to South Asia and Tibet,

¹³ His dismissal, along Sanderson's lines, of the "religious substratum model" on the ground of the absence of evidence is somewhat simplistic, reducing the issue to either a "devilishly clever" eradication of traces of primitive forms of Tantrism by the assimilating traditions (e.g. Śaivism, Buddhism, etc.), which he considers unlikely, or a total eradication by historical, cultural, economic, or other circumstances, which he considers a more cogent explanation, especially because "[t]hese postulated preassimilated forms of Tantrism were allegedly practiced by marginal, illiterate tribals, without the skills and finances necessary to leave lasting traces such as texts, statues, and inscriptions" (Wedemeyer 2013, p. 197).

¹⁴ This is all the more pertinent in the case of Southeast Asia. It is worth reminding that the oldest Sanskrit inscriptions from the region (ca. sixth century CE) are found in a remote area of present-day Kalimantan (Indonesian Borneo), which is populated by small-scale societies.

leaving Southeast Asia largely out of the picture. It is, therefore, high time to revive the quest for the origins of Tantrism from a wider geographical and historical perspective, and by making use of a comparative methodology. In revisiting the issue of a pan-Indian religious substratum—or, rather, of a shared cultural matrix—one may wonder, along with Dentan, whether this inferred matrix could have been part of an ancestral areal phenomenon that extended outside the borders of the Subcontinent, across what is now Southeast Asia, and perhaps even Southern China.¹⁵

4. A Shared Cultural Matrix in Monsoon Asia?

While surveying the scholarship on the “Indianization” of Southeast Asia in the past half a century or so, one notes a shift from a trans-local, “Greater India” perspective, to a more Southeast Asia-centred approach. This shift reflects new geopolitical scenarios, the compartmentalization of knowledge through an Area Studies approach in global academe, and the need to counteract the India-centric approach of earlier generations of scholars by attributing a greater agency to Southeast Asian people.

Yet, before the Greater India perspective became popular, French Indologists Jean Przyluski and Sylvain Lévi in the 1920s hypothesized the existence of a cultural substratum—labelled “Austroasiatic” (or “Austrie”)—common to South, Southeast, and parts of East Asia (Coedès 1968, pp. 8–9; 1944, pp. 8–9). An ancestral Austroasiatic/Austrie/Proto-Malay culture or civilization was inferred on the basis of evidence from linguistics, mythology, art history, and archaeology. This culture or civilization would have been characterized by the cult of ancestors, the worship of gods on high places, the figure of the “Lord of the Land”,¹⁶ similar funerary practices related to megalithic burials, matrilineal

¹⁵ While I believe that the southern part of China was closely involved in the cultural interactions that I am going to suggest, it has not been possible to include it in the present discussion, lest it assume unwieldy proportions. The same holds true for Papua New Guinea and Melanesia.

¹⁶ Cf. Wessing, this volume, on the theme of “Lord of the land” (*tuan tanah*) in Nusantara.

dualism, and structural analogies of myths; its technology would have included the use of complex irrigation systems for growing rice, and advanced skills in navigation. In the 1930s, Paul Mus elaborated on the idea of "Monsoon Asia" as an area characterized by an underlying cultural unity, which would explain the existence of some shared religious practices across it. According to Mus (1975, pp. 8–9 [1933]), through ethnography of the tribals of Vietnam,

it will be possible to start from the biased and relatively late evidence of the texts and work back to the ethnological conditions, or at any rate to social and religious conditions strictly anterior to the literary compilations. It will thus be possible gradually to restore many of the antecedents that have been subordinated and submerged by the brahmanical or confucian importations.

Further, Mus (1975, pp. 8–9) hypothesized

[t]he existence, in ancient times, of a certain unity of culture throughout an extensive zone in which India, Indo-China, Indonesia, a Pacific islands fringe and doubtless southern China are to be united.... whenever sea lanes establish communication, it is reasonable to expect a cultural unity, and it makes more sense to speak of a religion of the monsoon zone of Asia than to speak of Indian religion, or Chinese religion, prior to the civilizations which were later to give meaning to these words.

Mus reminds us that, in such a culturally diverse and widespread geographical area, this hypothesized unity is bound to remain a relative unity, the ultimate origin of which has to be "reconstructed"; yet this relative unity is particularly true in the domain of religion. To him, the fundamentals of the religion of the monsoon zone of Asia lay in worship of the energies of the soil deified as god (or goddess), the belief in a primeval spirit/energy permeating the whole nature, and the institution of mediumship. Mus then directs our attention to the belief in a collective divinity without individual personality in the autochthonous religions of many Southeast Asian tribal groups, which would be due to "a level of abstraction marking the termination of an already extensive process of elaboration" (*ibid.*, p. 12).

Coedès (1968, p. 8), who passed to history for his view that Southeast Asian people, although already civilized, advanced in many domains as a consequence of peaceful cultural and commercial interactions with the Indians, embraced Przyluski's—in his words, “prudent formula”—that “during the second Bronze Age [in Europe], the Indo-Chinese peninsula entered the orbit of a maritime civilization comprising both the mainland and the archipelago of Southeast Asia”. Coedès added that, whatever its origin, this civilization might have touched Japan, given the relations in the realm of language, folklore and material culture going back to the prehistoric period.¹⁷ In a remarkable paragraph, he clearly espoused Mus' idea of Monsoon Asia as an integrated cultural area:

Indians were not confronted by naked ‘savages’ but, on the contrary, *by people endowed with a civilization that had traits in common with the civilization of pre-Aryan India*. The speed and ease with which the Aryanized Indians propagated their culture is undoubtedly explained in part by the fact that, in the customs and beliefs of these immigrants, *the natives discovered, under an Indian veneer, a base common to all of monsoon Asia*. (ibid., p. 15; emphasis mine)

This “cultural matrix along a broad band stretching from pre-Aryan India through Island and Mainland Southeast Asia into Southern China” would comprise wet rice technology, bronze (the Dongson drums), the important role of women in societies, and distinctive social and mythological features (Reynolds 1995, pp. 422–23).

Following a similar train of thought, Richard Winstedt in his *The Malay Magician, Being Shaman, Shaiva, and Sufi* (1961) invoked an ancestral “paganism” common to tribals from India, Southeast Asia, and China:

¹⁷ Cf. Coedès 1968, p. 8, fns. 50–52. Kumar (2009) has suggested ancient Southeast Asian, and in particular Javanese, linguistic and cultural influences on Japan in the late prehistoric era. On the similarities between Japanese and Javano-Balinese masks posited by Coldiron, cf. below.

Europeans not presented with the evidence of geography, history and religions have been apt to talk as if Malay magic were unique and indigenous. (p. 1)

The Malays... have accepted the idea of two great civilisations, the Hindu and the Muslim, without abandoning their own prehistoric paganism. *That paganism can be reconstructed directly from study of backward tribes in Assam, Indochina and the Malay archipelago and, viewed more widely, is of a piece with the paganism of all the races from Southern India to China.* What has been written of every Dravidian village is true of every Malay village. (p. 4; emphasis mine)

While the quote by Winstedt transpires a judgemental positivism, its underlying idea of a "translocal paganism" covering a wide geographical area from Southern India to China is tantalizing, and calls to mind a paragraph by Hutton (1928, pp. 406–7) on the similar religious practices and beliefs of small-scale societies of Assam, island Southeast Asia, and Melanesia:

Beliefs as to the soul in the Celebes differ little, if not at all, from those in Assam, and to read an account of a hill tribe in Borneo or the Philippines gives a Naga Hills reader a vivid impression of reading of some Naga tribe with whose general culture he is perfectly familiar, but whose acquaintance he has never made.... There seems to be a pretty clear cultural connection between the Naga Hills and Melanesia.

The idea of a shared cultural matrix across Monsoon Asia, however outdated, romanticizing and far-fetched it may sound nowadays, is not altogether dissimilar from the scenarios that more recent scholars have suggested on the basis of extensive empirical work and more sophisticated theoretical models. Cases in point are Blust's acceptance of the "Austic hypothesis" positing a genetic relationship between Austroasiatic and Austronesian languages, and locating the ancestral habitat of the Austic family "in the general region where the Salween, Mekong and Yangzi rivers run parallel on the Burma-Yunnan frontier" (1996, p. 136); Blench's (2013) individuation of linguistic and cultural correlates between Eastern India and Melanesia; Reuter's (2014) description of an "Ancestor Religion" widespread in the Austronesian

world and East Asia; and Brighenti's (2005) discussion of buffalo sacrifices and mortuary rituals in tribal cultures of Monsoon Asia.

A brief review of the literature on cultural transfers between South and Southeast Asia further illuminates my point. For instance, in declaring that "Indianization of Southeast Asia" is a "confusion of categories", Mabbett (1977*a*, 1977*b*) suggested that the dichotomy between an autonomous Southeast Asia and a civilizing Indian culture was a false one, and that the two areas already shared common socio-cultural traits. Gutman, in a fashion that is strongly remindful of Mus, argued that Arakanese society was particularly receptive to Indian religion because it "was familiar in its substratum of beliefs developed in the same monsoon-dominated environment" (1976, p. 320). At a later date, Chihara (1996, p. 7) posited a "substratum of pre-Aryan culture" shared between India and Southeast Asia, and surmised that "there were few fundamental differences between Indian civilisation and Southeast Asian civilisation, [so] the wave of Indianisation would seem to have penetrated Southeast Asian societies as if by osmosis". Wolters (1999 [1982]) regarded the Southeast Asian region—and that region only, unlike his predecessors—as a "broadly based community of outlook", characterized by a shared "cultural matrix".

A theory focusing on "convergence" rather than a shared matrix (or substratum) has been advanced by Kulke (1990, p. 24). Kulke suggested that "the socio-political development of Eastern India during the first half of the first millennium AD... resembles in many respects the development in parts of Southeast Asia", which in its turn is indicative of a socio-cultural convergence on both sides of the bay of Bengal. Kulke's model of convergence between South and Southeast Asia, which redefines the process of Indianization as a "misnomer", may be regarded as either implying a shared cultural matrix, which would have led to parallel developments starting from similar premises and ending in similar results, or as being the outcome of independent origination.

When trying to transcend the nowadays likely old-fashioned "Indianization" paradigm, contemporary scholarship has emphasized cosmopolitan phenomena, and entertained the possibility of convergences across South and Southeast Asia. Nonetheless, in spite of occasional

winkings towards the existence of a shared cultural matrix in early Monsoon Asia, it seems to me that scholars have been hesitant to seriously consider the implications connected with that paradigm, failing to carry its premises to their logical conclusions. Besides Dentan, few have attempted to move beyond the paradigm of Indic/Sanskritic vs. “local” and revive the idea of an integrated Monsoon Asia. A relevant case study is that by Roy Jordaan and Robert Wessing (1999) on human and animal sacrifice in South and Southeast Asia.¹⁸ Situating themselves within the track started by Mus, Jordaan and Wessing replied to Henk Bodewitz’s challenging claim that construction sacrifice of humans had been unknown in India. Taking into account both ethnographic and textual data from various geographical areas of South Asia, Southeast Asia, and China, they pointed at the striking correspondences between construction sacrifice—which, in its Tantric form, might have involved human sacrifice—across Monsoon Asia and ritual prescriptions recommended by the Sanskrit *Śilpaśāstras*:

As Mus (1975:39) has argued, and as is borne out by the ethnographic literature (Wessing & Jordaan 1997), Indian usages can be seen as being but a local variant of practices once prevailing throughout ‘Monsoon Asia’, the difference between the Indian ones and the others lying in the fact that the former were infused with Vedic notions and later became doctrinized as ‘Hinduism’ (which itself is, of course, a cover term for a wide variety of beliefs and practices) while the others more or less remained folk practices.

Jordaan and Wessing (1999, p. 239)

As Jordaan and Wessing (*ibid.*, p. 218) put it, paraphrasing Mus, “a study of the customs of present-day groups in Southeast Asia, like the Cham in Vietnam, could teach us more about the hidden, still continuing pre-Aryan cultural influences which have contributed to the form that Hinduism has taken”. The desideratum put forward by these two scholars with respect to Hinduism and contemporary (ethnic) groups in Southeast Asia clearly resonates with that invoked by Dentan.

¹⁸ That book chapter in fact constitutes a sequel to earlier studies by the same authors, appeared in 1996 and 1997.

A similar view on the issue of “Indianization” has been advanced by John Emigh (1996) in his comparative study on Southeastern Indian (especially Orissan) and Javano-Balinese performance traditions and iconographic motifs. Emigh (1996, p. 96), in a series of striking paragraphs that are worth being quoted in full, attempted to go beyond the “(Indian/Tantric) influence” paradigm by positing a common ground for both areas:

What I am suggesting is that performative traditions, as well as linguistic and agricultural ones, may well have flowed south and west before returning towards the east; and that the Tantric traditions that took root in Bali may already have been nurtured in common ground. While independent invention is always a possibility, it is difficult to regard the dancing Shakti figures and not think of the ‘feminine’ *tubuan* coming from the wild *momboto* time in an act of visitation during mortuary rites of New Britain; on the gables of the men’s spirit houses in Iatmul villages, distant female cousins of the Kirtimukha and the guardian witch of Bali’s Goa Gajah can be found—tongues distended, horrific countenances in place.

We probably will not be able to fill in the blanks more precisely until further archaeological work is done to refine the nature of the trade contacts between South and Southeast Asia, a reassessment is made of the contributions of the Austro-Asiatic and Dravidian populations to ‘classical’ Indian culture in general, and more is known about the early cultural and historical links connecting the Indonesian archipelago to India, southern China, mainland Southeast Asia and Melanesia.

The current *calon arang*, like so many performative traditions, emerged after many passes from many directions, traces of which were kept and altered in a continuing process of accommodation, invention, and interpretation. It seems likely that both the Balinese *calon arang* and the Orissan Prahlada Nataka fundamentally grew out of related ritual and theatrical traditions connected to Shakti worship, and that these traditions were themselves made possible *by thousands of years of a partially shared prehistory*. (emphasis mine)

Emigh’s considerations on “thousands of years of a partially shared prehistory” as the catalyst for the emergence of mediaeval Tantric

ritual and performance traditions of South and Southeast Asia reminds us of Dentan's idea of an ancestral horrific Dark Lord—and the complex of motifs revolving around him, including conceptions of power as female and bloody sacrifices—deriving from a common source rather than being (uniquely) an Indic "import".

Scholar of performance Margaret Coldiron (2005*a*, 2005*b*) wonders whether a common origin can be postulated to explain the remarkable analogies between some masked theatrical characters in Japan and the Javano-Balinese world:

The masks are the dog/lions Shishi (Japan) and Barong (Bali), the witch-like Hannya (Japan) and Rangda (Bali), and the sacred old men Okina (Japan) and Sidha Karya (Bali). Whatever information exists concerning the sources of these masks is lost in the murky world of myth and legend, and the task of finding historical or archaeological evidence is further complicated by the ephemeral nature of the materials from which the masks are made, the paucity of documentary records concerning ritual and theatrical performance, and conflicting local traditions. The arguments I shall offer here are therefore speculations about matters for which there may be no definitive answers, but they form a part of my ongoing research into the possible source or sources of these images. Is there a cultural or historical link between them or is there some deeper, perhaps universal "source" for these archetypes that has given rise to such similar iconographic forms in these two quite separate cultures? (2005, p. 228)

Coldiron (2005*a*, p. 230) ventures to speculate that the similarities can be explained via a common (mediaeval) Tantric Buddhist source, or even via direct influence from Java.

Art Historian Natasha Reichle (2007, p. 157) discusses Batak religious lore as a case of convergence between imported Tantric cults and local beliefs. Quoting an account by Heine-Geldern on the central image at Bahal II at Padang Lawas, according to whom the worship of the fierce Heruka "formed a point of contact between the Indian and the indigenous rites... and gave impulse to the transformed interpretation of Batak cannibalism into a magic rite of degenerate Buddhism", she claims that the Bataks readily recognized their old indigenous elements

and customs in Tantric rites (ibid., p. 159).¹⁹ As a case in point, she compares the iconography and function of skull-topped magic staff carried by Batak shamans and the *khaṭvāṅga* carried by Śaiva and Buddhist Tantric practitioners and their elected deity, Heruka/Śaṃbara—who, as Bosch theorized, was the “special deity of sorcerers” (ibid., p. 161), and who, according to Przyluski (1937), originated in a pre-Aryan, Munda (i.e. Austroasiatic) linguistic and cultural substratum. Although Reichle herself does not make that point, one may wonder whether such case of convergence is due to independent invention or rather stems from an early layer that formed the shared matrix of both autochthonous and Indic Tantric elements. Cultural and religious phenomena that would seem to imply a convergence between certain Indic and Austronesian motifs in Java and Bali—namely, the five Śaiva seers (*pañcarṣi* or *pañcakuśika*) and related “mystical siblings” (*kanda mpat*)—have been described by Headley (2004, p. 123) and Acri (2014a). At the core of these similarities there lies an epistemic system of categorization of the internal and external universe through related series of visible and invisible interfaces that stand in meaningful relation to the individual, and provide the links to bridge different levels of reality. Whether this epistemic system developed from a common shared matrix or was “brought into sharper focus” (to say it with Wolters) by Indic influence is a question that awaits further investigation.

Clearly, in the absence of concrete data, any hypothesis concerning the origin of cultural phenomena in a remote past is bound to remain within the realm of speculation. Nevertheless, in recent years there has been an increasing tendency among scholars to map the possible common origins of cultural phenomena across different areas of the world, by resorting to oral history, mythology and folklore, and push back chronological boundaries into late prehistory (see, for example, Bellah 2011 on religion in human evolution). An ambitious and bold attempt to trace a shared

¹⁹ For example, the killing of a slave under the pole of a new house recalls the human sacrifices that were alleged to have taken place at Prambanan upon its consecration (see Jordaán and Wessing 1996; Wessing and Jordaán 1997).

ancestral global mythology back to a remote human past has been carried out by Sanskritist and Vedicist Michael Witzel in his recent monograph *The Origins of the World's Mythologies* (2012). Witzel individuates a "Laurasian mythology" diffused over North Africa, Eurasia and the Americas, and a "Gondwana mythology" found in sub-Saharan Africa, the Andaman Islands, Papua and Australia, as well as in smaller enclaves elsewhere, such as among the Todas in South India and the Semang in Malaysia. Witzel's hypothesis is relevant to our discussion insofar as (1) it individuates an ancestral areal phenomenon spanning the geographical extent of Monsoon Asia, and including Austroasiatic-speaking people of "Negrito" ethnic descent; (2) it employs a comparative and diachronic/phylogenetic methodology to explain the diffusion of mythologemes across the world. Witzel (2012, p. 279) admits that comparative mythology is not a hard science; however, reminding the reader that reconstruction of proto-Indoeuropean and other linguistic families is an established fact in science (p. 278), Witzel argues that the realm of mythology should be considered as a legitimate realm of enquiry to formulate hypotheses on the origin and migration of people, languages and cultures.²⁰

[p. 284] we can make predictions about which particular facts must have existed at certain stages in the past, as has been done successfully in historical comparative linguistics.... I assume the same can eventually be done for mythology, even though script and written texts earlier than c. 3000 BCE will hardly emerge to prove my case. Early human art, however, such as some cave paintings..., may indicate whether I have been right or not.... [R]econstructions of early mythologies that precede the Indo-European, Semitic, and Austronesian ones and so on... by 10,000 or more years can be made probable by detecting their common motifs, their structures, and eventually, their narrational frameworks.

²⁰ Witzel (2012, p. 46) rightly reminds us that "the historical comparative approach is not one of old-fashioned Romanticism looking for and speculating on distant *ur*-situations, but it is the cladistic procedure also used by genetics, human anthropology, archaeology, linguistics, and philological manuscript research: all of them present pedigrees or stemmas of subsequent historical layers and their interrelations, filiations, or branchings".

[285] Of great theoretical interest is the question of the close interlinking, or the side-by-side existence, of ‘genetically’ transmitted mythologies (that is, via a parents-to-children type of pedigree) and of those that have arrived by diffusion. Both can occur side by side within one and the same local mythology.

To illustrate his last point, Witzel embarks on an “imagined investigation”:

[286] *if we were ignorant of ancient European mythology and history, we might think of the various Christian myths and legends as typically European and wonder about their close relationship with those of Israel and the Near East. One might regard the Near East as an outlying area, not the actual center of diffusion. Nevertheless, we would be surprised by the large number of items in European folksongs, customs, and fairy tales that do not fit biblical topics at all, for example, the multifaceted role of the ‘devil’. Much of their individual background would quickly be ‘explained’ as being secondary explanations of natural phenomena and the like, which occur in other etiological tales.... Then, there are tales about the Milky Way as the path of the dead or the lambs, the threatening figure of the ‘Wild Hunter and his troop’ at Christmas, and so forth.... Pursuing this kind of imagined investigation, we would, however, quickly be led to conclude that these are remnants of an older level of European myth.* (emphasis mine)

Witzel’s thought experiment opens up fascinating scenarios for the study of the deep human past, suggesting as it does that scholars must try to resort to theoretical comparative reconstruction whenever “hard evidence” is not available—a process that is routinely applied by historical linguistics. Witzel’s imagined investigation may be translated into a metaphor that is relevant to the study of Indic religions over Monsoon Asia, where instantiations of Tantric cults known to us through the body of mediaeval texts, artefacts, and archaeological remains may be the result of a complex multi-directional historical process of transfer in the cadre of a region, to say it with Emigh, with “thousands of years of a partially shared prehistory”. Indeed, one may argue that what made possible at all the fruitful transfer, adoption and adaption of cultural tropes was a commonality of epistemes rooted in a shared matrix extending across Monsoon Asia.

5. The Religion of the Violent Godhead: Nkuu’, Rudra-Śiva, and Kāla-Bhairava

Having outlined the historiographic parameters of the issues under discussion, I will now test some of the hypotheses advanced by Dentan to support a connection between Semai religious tropes and aspects of Vedic and post-Vedic religion in India. Our starting point is the key figure of Nkuu’, the Semai godhead.²¹ What Indo-European ideologies call “devil” and “wild hunter and his troop” (Witzel 2012, p. 286) correspond to the “Dark Lord” and his malevolent hosts feared by the Semai, the Temiars, and their “Negrito” cousins from the Andaman islands to the Philippines.²² Dentan (2002a, p. 120) describes the salient elements of the postulated shared prehistoric religion as follows:

a high storm God feared but not worshiped; a notion of shamanic power embodied in demon wives; the use of blood to counteract that power; a congeries of particular sacred plants; and huge chthonic serpents or dragons associated with water.

On account of the feature shared by the two gods, Dentan argues that Nkuu’ would be the counterpart of Vedic Rudra (“the Howler”), which later developed into the Śiva of Classical Hinduism. Below I list the features pointed out by Dentan, then integrate them with new insights:

—*Associations with hunt, wilderness, and thunder(bolt)s.* The terrifying Godhead of the Semai is a frightening, violent, blood-thirsty, and tricksterish boogeyman-god (Dentan 2002a, p. 161). Like Nkuu’, and like the “Spectre huntsman” of the Malays (see below), Rudra

²¹ The word Nkuu’ is cognate with Malay *tengku*, “Prince” or “Lord” (also a title of nobility), of uncertain etymology (Dentan 2002a, p. 160). Nkuu’ is recognized as a thunder-god also by the Temiars, another aboriginal group of peninsular Malaysia, among whom he plays a major role as the embodiment of evil, known as Karey (Benjamin 2014, pp. 60, 195–96).

²² To Blust (2013), among the cultural evidence suggesting an ancestral historical relationship between the “Negritos” of the Philippines and those of the Malay Peninsula is precisely the name of the thunder god, as well as the “thunder-complex” (cf. below, fn. 57).

is wild and fierce—“a hunter in the wilderness whose abode is in the mountains in the north, who is clad in animal hide, has braided hair, and is excluded from the vedic sacrificial cult” (Bisschop 2013). Rudra, being initially an outsider, “by the end of the Vedic period... grew in stature, absorbing many aspects of other deities, especially Agni (fire, heat) and Indra (thunderbolt-bearer)” (ibid.).

- Ability to assume many forms; close ties with animals.* Just like the god of the Semai, Rudra-Śiva is capable of taking all forms (*viśvarūpa*), including that of animals (Dentan 2002a, p. 172; Bisschop 2013). Śiva wears or sits on a tiger skin, and rides a bull; Nkuu’ is sometimes conceived of as a monkey.
- Being “Lords of Beasts”.* The Lord from whom the Semai stole shamanic power is a “Lord of Beasts” (Dentan 2002a, p. 163).²³ This equals the appellative “Paśupati” of Rudra/Śiva in the post-Vedic early Śaiva tradition (where *paśu*, “beast”, has been “intellectualized” as a reference to the bound souls).
- Being not worshiped but feared/appeased.* Just like Nkuu’, Rudra is wild and fierce, “a terrible beast, like a wild storm” (Doniger O’Flaherty 1981, p. 219), worshiped “more in fear than in the spirit of devotion” (Doniger O’Flaherty 1975, p. 116), and “more to be pacified than to be adored” (ibid., p. 118); yet, in the Vedas he is invoked as healer and cooler of fevers. Śiva (“the benevolent”) is an apotropaic term for Rudra, worshipped to ward off his wrath. Bisschop (2013) points out that “a sense of fear underlies the depictions of Rudra in the Veda”, who comes across as a dangerous god; only three out of the 1,028 hymns of the *Rgveda* are exclusively dedicated to Rudra (for example, 1.114, 2.33, 7.46), and these

²³ Beyond the Semai, the idea that the godhead is a lord of beasts is also found among the Aetas (Negritos) of Luzon; to Winstedt, this fact suggests that “primitive man in south-east Asia had a god in a Lord of Beasts, the nomad’s food” (Winstedt 1961, p. 4).

play upon Rudra’s dangerous and unpredictable nature. He is typically requested not to strike with his arrows and to spare the cattle, children, and people of the village. However, these same hymns also stress Rudra’s healing powers. The god who strikes with disease and death also has the power to heal. These hymns are obviously meant to pacify a deity who could be malevolent if not treated properly.

Like Nkuu’, Rudra embodies the destructive aspect of a supreme deity who annihilates the universe at the end of a cosmic age.

- Malevolent offspring and demonic entourage.* Nkuu’ is chief of a host of fearsome demons (Dentan 2002a, p. 164), while Rudra is “the master of thousands of Rudras roaming in all directions” (Bisschop 2013). Rudra’s sons are sometimes identified with the Maruts, thundersquall gods who are part of his (or Indra’s) entourage (Dentan 2002a, p. 169), along with various categories of malevolent beings, such as *bhūtas*, *pretas* and *piśācas*. There is an association between Sanskrit *piśāca* “flesh eater” and Semai *ceep caa’ sej* “flesh-eater birds” (or bees), which are associated with Nkuu’; in both contexts, these are malevolent beings regarded as bugs and creeping creatures. Rudra and his hypostases (e.g. Tumburu) are associated with wrathful female deities, and supernatural female beings called *ḍākinīs* or *yoginīs* (see below).
- Relationship with power, theorized as female (and often demonic).* In the Indic sphere, we find the concept of Śiva’s *śakti*, and such figures as the *ḍākinīs/yoginīs*. Dentan (2002a, pp. 163–64) discusses a conceptualization of power as female, and its articulation through an erotic relationship between Semai adepts and demonic wives. Furthermore, there appears to be a parallel between seven power-bestowing female deities among the Semai and the Indic Kṛttikās/Mātṛs (see below).
- Association with a congeries of particular sacred plants.* Besides Nkuu’, this is also the case of Tumburu, an early form of Rudra, and of his hypostasis Kāla/Vanaspati (see below).

If taken singularly, these—admittedly rather generic—ideas and activities could be regarded as the result of independent creation,

while linguistic borrowings may be seen as Sanskritic influxes into Semai language. However, if taken collectively, and especially when reinforced with evidence of linguistic and cultural contact between the Indo-Aryan and the Austroasiatic spheres, they may suggest that more complex circulatory processes were at play.

The similarities outlined above are mostly between Nkuu' and Śiva in the form of Rudra, the terrible outsider god of the Vedic and early post-Vedic textual corpus, i.e. the earliest stage of what we now call "Hinduism". Dentan did not discuss the later historical development of that deity, which gave rise to the hypostases of Tumburu, Bhairava, and Kāla, as attested in the enormous Tantric textual corpus that came to the fore since ca. the fifth century CE in the Indian Subcontinent and the wider Indic world. It is this literature, and other contemporary genres that were influenced by it in both South and Southeast Asia, which yields some interesting leads for further comparison. Below I present some additional evidence drawn from Sanskrit and Old Javanese textual sources, as well as ancient and modern Javano-Balinese folklore, that would appear to substantiate some of Dentan's claims with respect to the existence of a link between Semai lore and (Tantric) Hinduism.

5.1 Of Words

Possible historical links between Nkuu' and Rudra may be found in the traces of Sanskrit vocabulary featuring in Semai mythology. As we have seen above, there exists a thematic relationship between Sanskrit *piśāca* and Semai *ceep caa' sej*, a category of flesh-eating malevolent beings associated to Rudra and Nkuu' respectively. The Sanskrit form might have been borrowed from Austroasiatic, as suggested by the obvious relation between phonetic and morphological elements: the former word may be an inversion and contraction of the latter (*ceep* > *piś*, *caa' sej* > *śaca*); alternatively, both words could have derived from a common proto-form.²⁴ Conversely, terms of likely Sanskrit derivation attested in

²⁴ Notably, the largely unattested Paiśācī language ("the language spoken by flesh-eating ghouls", *piśāca*) is connected in Sanskritic imaginary to an archaic language current among (Austroasiatic-speaking) tribal communities of the Indian Subcontinent.

Semai language are *mrgaas* (< Skt *mṛga*),²⁵ *dangaa'* or *naga'* (< Skt *nāga*),²⁶ and *rahuu'* (< Skt *Rāhu*) (Dentan 2002a, pp. 163, 169). *Rahuu'* (“Dark cloud”), denoting the home of *Nkuu'*, is obviously derived from the Sanskrit *Rāhu*, “the Seizer”—a mythological and astronomical dragon-like demonic character who swallows the sun and moon during eclipses (see Figure 3.1).²⁷ Dentan notes that the existence of these Sanskrit terms among the Semai may be explained as borrowings; yet, the related Indic concepts they carry usually retain a secondary role: “although there are filigrees of Śaivism in Semai theology, its core seems indigenous” (2002a, p. 171).

Rāhu is a prominent figure in the literatures and arts of both peninsular and insular Southeast Asia. In mediaeval Indic lore, *Rāhu* is presided over by the demonic aspect of Śiva known as *Kāla* (“the Black/Dark One”, or “Time”, as devourer of everything) or *Bhairava*. In Java and Bali, as well as in the Malay world, *Kāla* is conceived of as Śiva’s unruly son, who stole the elixir of life from the gods and got burnt in the process, keeping only his head; *Kāla(mukha)* is often depicted as eating the sun (i.e. during eclipses) or devouring himself. An equivalence between *Kāla*, *Rāhu*, and *Kīrtimukha/Kālamukha* (also called *Vanaspati/Banaspati*)²⁸ in Java and Assam, *Boma* in Bali, and *Vajramastaka* in Orissa) may be established with respect to the widespread architectonic element (demon-head) standing as a guardian above doorways of temples and monumental

²⁵ As Semai mythology has it, “to commit the incest, both the Creator and His daughter took the form of deer, *mrga*. Deer seem to be the mothers of sacred cows in India and are associated with motherhood and incest by Semai; but the Semai term *mrgaas* is a euphemism for ‘tiger’, the embodiment of the violent shamanic power which the Lord God stupidly gave to humans” (Dentan 2002a, p. 169). For an alternative etymology (of the possibly related Temiar word *mērgēeh* “demoniac”), see Benjamin 2014, p. 125, fn. 33.

²⁶ That word, and the related concept, is also found among the Temiars (Benjamin 2014, p. 183); see discussion below, p. 114.

²⁷ For a discussion of this word among the Temiars, see Benjamin 2014, p. 57.

²⁸ This means “the king of the wood” in Sanskrit, and may at times indicate the fig tree, or timber. The Javano-Balinese form *Banaspati*, used to refer to the *Kālamukha/Kīrtimukha* element, appears to have a counterpart in India as well: cf. *vanaspatīśiras* (“the head of *Vanaspati*”) invoked in the *Niśvāsaguhya* (2.90b), belonging to the early Śaiva Tantra *Niśvāsataṭṭvasaṃhitā* (cf. the analogous, and tautologic, compound *rāhuśiras*).

FIGURE 3.1



**Rāhu (note the Kīrtimukha at the top),
Konarak, Orissa, Thirteenth Century
(now at British Museum)**

Source: Courtesy of Redtigerxyz at English
Wikipedia (Wikimedia Commons).

edifices in Southeast Asia, India, and Nepal (see Figure 3.2).²⁹ White (2010, p. 206) points out that in the Kathmandu Valley Bhairava is often represented as nothing but a face or head (the Kīrtimukha among them), and fanciful stories are offered to account for this fact. These elements highlight the fascination for the terrible aspect of the godhead (and his various emanations) current in the Indic world, and especially in Southeast Asia.

²⁹ For a discussion of the Kāla/Kīrtimukha motif in the Indic world, see Dhar 2007.

FIGURE 3.2



Kāla Heads (Kīrtimukha), Trowulan Museum, East Java
Source: Author.

While so far we have considered some concepts and Sanskrit loanwords found among the Semai and Indicized societies of Southeast Asia, we may now investigate loanwords of putative Austroasiatic origin occurring in Sanskrit literature from South Asia. These may bear some relevance to the much-debated issue of origin of the figure of Rudra-Śiva and its cults, which, as remarked by Bisschop (2013), seem to have originated in a “complex cultural background in which both vedic and extra-vedic elements have played a role”. Dentan’s hypothesis concerning the common origin of Rudra and Nkuu’ in a pre- or non-Aryan, i.e. Austroasiatic cultural milieu addresses these points, yet needs to be tested from a historical perspective grounded in linguistic and textual data. A possible pointer to a pre-Aryan context is the presence of Austroasiatic words in the early Śaiva vocabulary and cultic stock. By “Austroasiatic” here I mean words borrowed from attested Munda languages, which belong to the Austroasiatic family of languages.³⁰ While Austroasiatic languages are mainly represented in mainland Southeast Asia (i.e. Vietnamese, Khmer and Mon, as well as the Aslian language spoken by the Semai and other ethnic minorities), pockets of speakers of Austroasiatic languages are found in Central and Eastern India and in the Andaman and Nicobar islands.

It has been long since noted that some words for cultigens in (Middle) Indo-Aryan languages have been borrowed from Austroasiatic languages: see Masica (1979) with respect to Hindi, and Southworth (2005, p. 223) with respect to Sanskrit (and a possible Southeast Asian origin for seven crops). The historical/migratory dynamics behind the Austroasiatic influence on (Middle) Indo-Aryan languages are still unclear. Most scholars accept the Austroasiatic language family as forming, along with the Dravidian, a linguistic layer existing prior to the arrival of Indo-Aryan languages into the (central and southern parts

³⁰ Problems still exist in the classification of Austroasiatic languages (see Sidwell 2015, pp. 144–49). For instance, an increasing number of scholars now think that the Munda languages do not form a primary-level subdivision of Austroasiatic separate from Mon-Khmer, and the very term “Mon-Khmer” is currently being replaced by “Austroasiatic” (p.c. Geoffrey Benjamin, June 2015).

of the) Indian Subcontinent,³¹ yet the issue of the origin of the Austroasiatic-speaking Munda populations—whether from South or Southeast Asia—remains controversial.³² According to Gupta (2005, p. 22), “The Austroasiatic infusions into Sanskrit can perhaps be best explained in terms of maritime crossings from Southeast Asia to peninsular India in some undetermined time in antiquity”;³³ indeed, parallels in the Calcolithic and Neolithic material culture of Eastern India and mainland Southeast Asia have been regarded as evidence of overlaps, or even influence from the latter area on the former (Gupta 2005, pp. 22–23; Selvakumar 2011, pp. 201–2; Gaillard, Singh, and Dambricourt Malassé 2012; Blench 2013, p. 12). Elst (2005, pp. 255–56) argues that “at least linguistically, the Munda tribals are not ‘aboriginals’ (with a pseudo-native modern term, *ādivāsi*), but carriers and importers of Southeast-Asian culture”,³⁴ while Blench (2013) individuates an “arc of vegeculture” stretching between Melanesia and Eastern Nepal that, correlating with linguistic evidence and material culture items, may have constituted an early corridor of diffusion of ideas. Peterson (forthcoming) suggests that what has been labelled by Bronkhorst “Greater Magadhan” culture of Northeastern India may have been substantially influenced by a considerable number of autochthonous Munda-speaking linguistic groups who at that time were

³¹ Similarly, (proto-)Austroasiatic may have formed the earliest linguistic phylum in Southeast Asia, and indeed Austroasiatic lexicon is found in some Austronesian languages (especially Chamic and some Malay dialects).

³² It is now recognized by historical/comparative linguistics that the separation of the two main Austroasiatic subfamilies—Munda and Mon-Khmer—must be placed well back in prehistory (see Riccio et al. 2011 and Chaubey et al. 2011 for a discussion in the light of genetic evidence). Blust (1996, p. 132) suggests that by 7,000–7,500 BP, Proto-Austroasiatic had already separated into Munda and Mon-Khmer dialect areas: Munda moved “down the Brahmaputra Valley into Assam and Bangladesh, gradually spreading westward, and Mon-Khmer down the Salween and Mekong valleys into mainland Southeast Asia”.

³³ Mahdi (this volume) argues that the Austroasiatic-speaking Negritos were the first to navigate in a remote past. If this was the case, they might have taken along other tangible and intangible cultural goods to South and East Asia.

³⁴ On the cultural and linguistic evidence supporting the existence of almost certain historical relationship among the Austroasiatic-speaking Negrito groups of Southeast Asia (and perhaps of the Andaman Islands too), see Blust 2013.

only beginning to be assimilated into the culture of the Indo-Aryan-speaking “invaders”, and who did not recognize the Brahmans as the highest class of society. At the same time, he advances the working hypothesis that the Munda languages, which today are restricted to four residual zones in the Subcontinent, were once spoken over a much wider area (at least in the eastern half of the Indo-Gangetic plain). Be this as it may, what is relevant to our discussion is that 1) the Austroasiatic-speaking ethnic groups scattered over the eastern (and insular) areas of the modern Indian Subcontinent may carry, in a modified form, cultural themes that are/were shared by their Southeast Asian Negrito cousins (see Dentan, this volume); and 2) given the relative paucity of Austroasiatic loan-words in (Middle) Indo-Aryan languages (ca. 6 per cent, see Witzel 1999a), even in domains where loanwords abound (e.g. agriculture), the influx of ultimately Austroasiatic terms into the Sanskrit Śaiva cultic sphere is an intriguing fact.

An Austroasiatic loan-word associated to the earliest Indian phase of Śaivism (ca. third to fifth century CE) is *lākula*, which we find in the Sanskrit forms *Lakulīśa* (“the Lord with the Club”) and *Lāguḍi/Lākulin* (“club-bearer”). Conceived of as the human incarnation of Śiva-Rudra in the corpse of a Brahmin, this central figure of Pāśupatism was venerated as a teacher and promulgator on earth of the Śaiva doctrine. Przyluski (1929a, pp. 8–15) derived *lākula* from the Austroasiatic *lāṅgula* (“penis”, “stick”), which is related to *lāṅgala* (“plough”, “digging-stick for ploughing”).³⁵ The origin of the word *laguḍa/lakuṭa* and its use in Sanskrit literature in the sense of “club” is not yet clear (Bakker 2011, pp. 27–28); nonetheless, Przyluski’s equation with the

³⁵ See Shorto 2006, p. 448 (**lngal*, **ṅgal*; by dissimilation **lnguur*; **lngu[ə]r* “plough”), and Turner 1966 s.v. *lāṅgūla* (“tail”, adj. “having a tail”, “penis”); cf. **laṅga*3 (“end of loincloth”, cf. *laṅja*3 “end of cloth tucked in behind”, possibly same as *laṅja*2 “tail”?, and connected with *liṅga*). Southworth (2005, p. 68) regards *lāṅgala* as “[o]ne important word which seems to have a clear A[ustro] A[sianic] source”; Hoogervorst (2013, p. 3, fn. 1) points out that “an Austro-Asiatic origin of OIA **lāṅgala* ‘plough’ is certainly plausible from the perspective of Mon-Khmer linguistics”, and that these forms “presumably stood at the head of a series of loanwords in Malayo-Polynesian languages”.

Austroasiatic *lāṅgula* in the meaning of “stick” or “penis” is convincing, as an analogy between the club and the phallus in early iconography of (itiphallic) Lakulīśa may be established.³⁶ Notably, a cognate (likely Austroasiatic) word is *liṅga*, which plays an important role in Śaiva worship.

Another Sanskrit word of putative Austroasiatic origin that is connected to the early phase of Śaivism in both the Subcontinent and Southeast Asia is *tumburu*. Przyluski (1929*b*, p. 154ff.) traced it back to *uḍumbara/udumbara*, a type of fig-tree, which may be related to *tumba*, a cucurbit.³⁷ While there has been a lot of discussion as to whether the *udumbara*, and fig- or banyan-trees in general, were assimilated by Vedic Hinduism from an Austroasiatic-speaking Negrito or Austronesian-speaking milieu (see Dahlquist 1977, pp. 230–31, Mahdi 1999, pp. 189–209), the tropes associated with the deity named Tumburu (whatever the origin of the word may be) are remindful of the similarities individuated by Dentan with respect to Rudra and Nkuu'. Tumburu originally ranked among the Gandharvas—the celestial flying-musicians headed by Indra, the thunderbolt-bearing god—, and featured in the *Atharvaveda* as a healing tree or tree-god bearing that

³⁶ See Turner 1966 s.v. *lakuṭa*. Bakker (2011) mentions Przyluski's hypothesis in connection with the genesis of Lakulīśa en passant, while discussing more elaborately Ingall's hypothesis of a Greek origin (from Heracles). To Bakker, “even if we do not accept Przyluski's etymology that links the word to the Austro-Asiatic *lāṅgula*, meaning ‘stick’ or ‘penis’, we may assume that phallic symbolism easily suggested itself to the Indian mind and came to be associated with this particular attribute” (p. 28).

³⁷ *Udumbāra* is considered Austroasiatic also by Mayrhofer (1956, vol. I, p. 104; cf. Turner 1966 s.v.), and identified with *Ficus glomerata* or *Ficus racemosa*, native of Australia, Malaysia, Southeast Asia and the Indian Subcontinent; Austroasiatic **ṭumba* (Skt *tumbā*, cf. *gōḍumbikā*, Turner 1966 s.v.) is a cucurbit of *coloquintida* (*Lagenaria vulgaris*) that, like a large number of gourds, are of Eastern Asiatic origin. Tumburu may also betray a contamination with the instrument *ṭamburā vīṇā*—for Tumburu is the king of the Gandharvas—, and perhaps be related to *ḍombā*, “outcaste tribe” (see Przyluski 1929*b*, pp. 149–55ff.). Southworth (2005, p. 74) considers this etymology “tortuous” and, in spite of the difference between “fig” and “date”, suggests a derivation from Dravidian “fig/date tree” (Proto-Dravidian **uttu* “date”, **mara* “tree”).

name (Griffiths 2004–5).³⁸ In Śaiva and Buddhist Tantric literature he is first represented as a harmful demon to be warded off, then identified with (a manifestation of) Śiva/Bhairava and ultimate revealer of the north/left-facing stream (*vāmastrotas*) of the Śaiva textual corpus. In the *Vīṇāśikhatantra*, one of the early Śaivatantras stemming from that stream (Goudriaan 1985, p. 4), he represents the paramount aspect of Śiva indeed; his four *śaktis* or sisters, Jayā, Vijayā, Ajitā, and Aparājitā, play a central role in his cult. Tumburu was known in Cambodia, Bali, and China by the 9th century.³⁹ Bourdonneau (2011, p. 1357) describes Tumburu as a divinity with a royal dimension, but also as a warring god, prolonging the human life, a protective yet ambivalent divinity able to exercise destructive powers. This ambiguity is concretized by the terrible goddesses who form his entourage. These could be either the four above-mentioned sisters or the seven or eight Mother Goddesses (*Mātṛs*). Tumburu spearheads these deities and can also act as a mitigator to their nefarious influences (Goudriaan 1985, p. 23; Sanderson 2001, p. 46; Hatley 2007, p. 142).⁴⁰

Hatley (2007, p. 282) regards the cult of the Sisters of Tumburu as “most historically significant”, and connects it to a later Tantric corpus (the Bhairatavatantras and Yoginītantras) centred around the cult of

³⁸ Griffiths traces Tumburu to the Vedic *tumburu/audumbara*, a copper-coloured fig tree belonging to the *Zanthoxylum* species. In *Paippalādasamhitā* 15.23.3–4, Tumburu protects from thunderbolt (“we keep away the Thunderbolt with a branch of the Udumbara”), whereas in 61.9 it is counterposed to hypostases of Rudra: “Bhava (= Rudra) does not strike, Śarva (= Rudra) does not shoot [his] arrow, there where you, o heavenly Tumburu, grow wide on the mountains” (ibid.). A relation between *tumburu* and *udumbara/udumbalā* seems likely, also in view of the fact that both words are associated with red/copper-colour (see Witzel 1983 on the latter; note that in *R̥g Veda* 10.14.12, *udumbalā* is referred to Yama’s demonic dogs).

³⁹ On Tumburu and his four sisters, see Goudriaan 1973 and Goudriaan 1985, pp. 18–30, 47–48; cf. Sanderson 2001, pp. 8, 12–13, 32; Sanderson 2003–4, pp. 355ff., 373ff.; Sanderson 2004, p. 278). On the verses of the *Vīṇāśikhatantra* found in a Sanskrit magical *stuti* from Bali, see Goudriaan 1973, pp. 51–56.

⁴⁰ Hatley (2007, p. 146) notes that in the early Tantric Buddhist text *Mañjuśrīmūlakalpa* “the iconography of the Four Sisters and Tumburu has unusual maritime elements. The Four Sisters are repeatedly described as mounted in a boat... with Tumburu as the helmsman” (cf. *Netratāntra* 11.25cd–26ab).

Rudra-Bhairava and associated with malignant magical practices and exorcism, the Bhūtatāntras, and one concerned with the cult of Ḍākinīs and Yoginīs. He (ibid., p. 143) describes these female beings as largely malevolent and parasitic, but also as bestowers of supernatural powers on yogins who invoke or worship them through mantras, or actually copulate with them. Further, he (ibid., p. 32) points out that “it has been widely acknowledged that yoginīs have roots in early traditions of Mother goddesses, *māṭṛs* or *māṭṛkās*, whose qualities they inherit in no small measure”. These Māṭṛs become widespread in the Gupta era, and may be the result of cultural assimilation. There may be a historical connection between the Tantric Māṭṛs or Yoginīs/Ḍākinīs, whose cult was widespread throughout the mediaeval period, and the Vedic Māṭṛs, the wives of the seven sages or seers (*saptarṣi*). Dentan (2002a, p. 166) has argued that there is a parallel between seven power-bestowing female deities among the Semai and the Indic Māṭṛs/Kṛttikās:

Shamanic powers came to humans via the seven Original Adepts (*halaa’ asal*) and Original Midwives; as seven is not a traditional magic number in Semai culture, these are obviously derived from the Vedic seven sages (*saptarṣi*) and their wives, the seven *kṛttikas*, ‘cutters or razors’. As the seven Seers founded Hinduism, so the seven Adepts founded Semai shamanism. Since Semai freely add exogenous explanatory accounts of various phenomena to indigenous ones..., perhaps they just tacked the Seers and Razors onto their own ideology, without bothering with details.

Early Sanskrit sources, such as the *Mahābhārata*, as well as Kuṣāṇa-period sculptural evidence, attest to an association between these Māṭṛs/Kṛttikās and Skanda/Kumāra, Śiva’s son;⁴¹ the accounts “are many and highly layered, no doubt the products of a long development” (Hatley 2007, p. 36). In fact, Parpola (1985, pp. 121, 151) traces the genealogy of the Kṛttikās to the Indus Valley Civilization through the Mohenjo-

⁴¹ See discussion in White 2003, pp. 35–63; cf. *Mañjuśrīmūlakalpa* 22.24b, mentioning the Skandamāṭṛs (ed. Vaidya 1964).

darō “fig deity seal”. It is interesting in the present context to point out that the names of most of these Kṛttikās (= Pleiades) betray non-Indoeuropean origins—possibly Austroasiatic: *ambā*, *dulā/buḷā*, *nītatnī*, *cupuṇīkā*. *Ambā* and *Cupuṇīkā*, as well as the remaining three, show an association with water, rain and cloud (and therefore, the monsoon), e.g. *abharayantī*, *meghayantī*, *varṣayantī*.⁴² According to Newar folklore, the Kṛttikās are the mothers of Kumāra (i.e. Skanda), the rain-child whose birthday rite is celebrated at the beginning of the rainy season. The word *kumāra* (“young man”) itself has been identified as an Austroasiatic/Para-Munda borrowing (Southworth 2005, p. 68), while the identification of Skanda with Murugan, a South Indian deity, may reflect a process of Vedic-Dravidian synthesis that is also represented in the story of Murugan’s two consorts, one of whom is seen as the daughter of a tribal chief (Frazier 2011, p. 303). As suggested by Vajracharya (1997), an emphasis on water, rain, and seasonal atmospheric phenomena may be indicative of an influence of “monsoonal culture” of non-Aryan agriculturalist populations on Vedic nomadic culture.⁴³

⁴² Interestingly, these are also the names of bricks in the *agnicayana* (Witzel 1999b). *Cupuṇīkā*, related to *nicumpuṇa*, “effusion, bubbling, water spirit” (Witzel 1999b), “flood” (Keith, in Kuiper 1991, p. 85), is one of the Pleiades’ stars. In early Kuṣāṇa art from Mathura, the Kṛttikās are depicted holding river/cloud as their main attributes (Vajracharya 1997). The fifth-century stone inscription of Gaṅgdhār (Rajasthan) mentions a “terrifying home of the Mothers, filled with female demons (*dākinī*).... These Mothers impel the great booming of the rain clouds and rouse the ocean with the mighty wind that arises from the *tāntras* (*sic*)” (Sullivan 2006, p. 11). In general, the Goddess (and her various embodiments) is regarded to rule over plants and favour fertility/rains, and worshiped in specific trees, among them the Banyan and the Sal.

⁴³ Vajracharya argues that, while the *Avesta* shows little interest in rain-making, “the *R̥gveda* is full of prayers for rain and contains many different speculations about the phenomena of rain and lightning”. This would reflect the growing importance of the monsoon as the Indo-Aryans moved toward the basin of the Ganges in the Subcontinent. According to Vajracharya, deities such as Indra and Varuṇa, who originally had nothing to do with the phenomena of rain, due to the association of agriculture with the monsoon became regarded as rain makers; for instance, Varuṇa was originally the god of the night sky representing the primeval water and later became the god of the Indian monsoon, while Indra’s slaying of Vṛtra should be interpreted, besides as a creation myth, also as a story of “drought and rain”.

The parallels outlined above, both distributional (i.e. linguistic) and functional, between Semai and Sanskritic lore may be regarded as the result of a (superficial) Indic influence, as hinted at by Dentan in the case of Sanskrit loanwords and related concepts adopted by the Semai. While the existence of some Austroasiatic words associated with the early cult of Rudra-Śiva and his entourage in the Indian Subcontinent do not allow us to make any assumptions of a wide-ranging nature, they may nonetheless lead us to reconsider the matter of directionality, especially in the light of Dentan’s hypothesis concerning the existence of shared religious tropes across Monsoon Asia in pre- or proto-historical times and a subsequent “convergence” in historical times. By pinpointing those Austroasiatic loans I do not intend to “prove” a direct influence of a putative Austroasiatic religion on Indo-Aryan milieux, but rather strengthen the view, already advanced by many scholars, that the early phase of Śaivism was indeed shaped by both Vedic and non-Vedic cultural milieux, in which the carriers of an “Austroasiatic cultural package” could have played a role.

5.2 On the Feminine as Power

Dentan (2002a) has noted an association between shamanic power, the Lord Nkuu’, fierce/bloody rituals, and (demonic) female practitioners among the Semai:

[A] person’s shamanic power is his ‘wife’.... Semai adepts and successful hunters have demonic wives. (p. 163)⁴⁴

Some Semai strive to connect to the fearsome demons of which the Lord is chief. The relationship is erotic and produces an altered state of consciousness that resembles an erotic ecstasy. The Semai use the Arabic word *asyik*, which refers to loss of self in both sexual and divine unions. (p. 164)

[W]hile Semai adepts are not ascetics, they often have to restrict their diets and behaviour in order to placate their demonic wives/familiar. (p. 166)

⁴⁴ The Temiars use *gunig* (from Malay *gundik* “consort, secondary wife”) as one of their words for “spirit-guide”, male or female (Benjamin 2014, p. 35).

Semai conceptions of, and metaphors for, power recall a constellation of themes found in South Asian Tantric cults. In these cults the providers of supernatural powers are often the Yoginīs or Mātr̥s, semi-divine (or demonic) female beings who may entertain an erotic partnership with male adepts. White (2003, p. 8) characterizes Yoginīs as

preternatural or supernatural hybrid between the human, animal, bird, and plant worlds... terrible and benign with regards to humans, who traditionally worshiped them with blood offerings and animal sacrifice. Once gratified by said oblations, the Yoginīs would reveal themselves as ravishing young women and gratify their human devotees with supernatural powers.

Yoginīs were worshiped in the erotico-mystical milieu of the Kaula Tantric stream, which focused on the (internalized) cult of “clan deities” (*kuladevatā*). This cult was not limited to elite milieux, but was widespread in society, as can be evinced from its presence in Indic folklore and, more importantly, among Austroasiatic-speaking Munda tribal groups. Among the Santals of eastern India, Yoginīs or female Tantric deities called *boṅgas* “often interact with human beings and are attractive to humans [... and] are often said to become the lovers or ‘spirit wives’ of human beings” (McDaniel 2013, p. 136); just like Yoginīs (and the “spirit wives” of the Semai), “[*b*]oṅga wives give blessings, wealth and supernatural powers”; however, they “may also be hostile and vengeful” (ibid., p. 137). To Davidson (2002, p. 198), adepts of a sort of “disciplined eroticism” conceived as a means to spiritual liberation, attracted one such non-human women in a secluded place, in order that their sanctified sexual intercourse would yield worldly benefits. Samuel (2008, p. 246) describes Kāpālīka-style power-seeking sorcerers who

were linked to their relationships with the female spirits and/or human female practitioners known as *yoginīs*, *ḍākinīs*, and by other names. These were frightening and dangerous spirits, and they form part of an ‘alternative pantheon’ of dark and scary female deities associated with Bhairava and his various transforms.

In Semai shamanic seances, the joining of opposites resembles the relationship between *śakti*, i.e. energy/supernatural power intended as female, and a male divine or human actor. Furthermore, there is a relationship with (female menstrual) blood and the shamanic power of counteracting the influence of demonic beings and Nkuu' himself: "Semai women slash their shins and throw the 'heating' blood into the rain to repel the Lord God" (Dentan 2002a, p. 167). A ritual of thigh-blood sacrifice, where the practitioner outpours his or her own blood (perhaps in substitution of human sacrifice), is enacted by the Austroasiatic-speaking Munda people of the Chhota Nagpur plateau to propitiate the female divinities or spirits called *saket-bongas* (*saket* < Skr. *śakti*); those spirits are the tutelary deities of the Santal mediums called *ojhās*, who used to offer their blood in fulfillment of a vow (Brighenti 2009, p. 77).⁴⁵ In mediaeval South Asia, the power of Yoginīs "was intimately connected to the flow of blood, both their own sexual and menstrual emissions, and the blood of their animal (and human?) victims" (White 2003, p. 27). Samuel (2006, p. 26) outlines the pan-Indic, trans-local nature of the cult of fierce female spirit-deities, which has its roots in the Gupta period, and reaches the periphery of the Indic world:

The female deities associated with the fierce deity rituals are closely linked to a class of Indian spirits who cause disease and are propitiated to bring healing. Versions of such female deities can be found in the *Mahābhārata* and in early medical texts, and they have remained staples of folk and village ritual into modern times. The set of deities known as the Saptamātṛkā, though mostly presented as consorts to the major Brahmanical deities, make up a Brahmanical version of these disease-spirits... masked figures possessed by these deities have played an important role in the ritual cycles of Hindu communities from the Nepal Valley to Kerala, Bengal, and Bali.

⁴⁵ Brighenti also describes the sacrifice of *bul-mayam* offered to *bongas* of purely Santal origin by the non-Hinduized tribal priests called *kudam naeke*, who offer drops of their blood mixed with rice.

The Semai regard dragons called *dangaa'* or *naga'* (Skt *nāga*) as wives of the Lord Nkuu'. These beings recall the serpentine female beings (*nāgī*, *nāginī*) of Indic lore, who were conceived of as carriers of supernatural power. Male heroes who engaged in erotic or romantic relationships with *nāgīs* became the founders of royal dynasties in various areas of South and Eastern India, Southeast Asia (Cambodia, Java), and China; a cult of serpents embodied in *Nāgas*, intended as benign beings who bestow wealth and power has been interpreted as non- or pre-Indo-Aryan in origin, as it is prevalent in the same areas.⁴⁶ Przyluski (1924) discussed examples of (sexual) union between a human being and an aquatic creature—usually a fish—recorded in Indian and Chinese mythology and folklore, concluding that the area from where this theme originated was the “maritime civilization” of Southeast Asia, and in particular the Austroasiatic- (and, I would add, Austronesian-) speaking populations living along the shores of rivers or on the sea. The fish eventually became a *Nāga* in India and a “dragon” in China. To him, as was already noted by Finot (1911, p. 32), the connection between the transmission of sovereignty and women would fit societies in which a matrilinear system of succession was implemented, such as among several ethnic groups of Southeast Asia. More recently, Mahdi (1999) has proposed a Southeast Asian pedigree for the pre-Aryan populations called *Nāgas* in Sanskrit sources on account of their maritime orientation, associations with piracy, and a cult of serpents and sacred fig trees.

Although the impressionistic and perforce general discussion offered in the above paragraphs is only preliminary, it nonetheless suggests

⁴⁶ See Spagnoli 2002 for a survey of the topic and the secondary literature. The cult of *Nāgas* has been fully integrated within Hinduism and Buddhism, where they represented tribal deities “tamed” by Buddhist (e.g. Vajrapāṇi) or Hindu deities, which in turn would indicate a paradigm expressing the victory over tribal religion (Verardi 2011). In Tantric Buddhism we find a connection between *Nāgas* and important masters (*Nāgārjuna*, *Nāgabuddhi*) and localities (e.g. *Nāgārjunakoṇḍa*); according to post-eighth century Buddhist hagiography, the scriptural canon of Tantric Buddhism was received by Vajrasattva from the *Nāgas*, and then revealed to *Nāgārjuna* in an iron tower in Central India.

that some functional and distributional similarities existed between the various forms and transformations of female deities—from the Mātṛs to the Yoginīs, Nāgīs, and *bongas*—and their relationship to practitioners, blood, and sacrifice across both Indic and “tribal” religions attested across South and Southeast Asia. If anything, this state of affairs speaks in favour of the existence of closer interactions between the cultures of Indo-Aryan-, Austroasiatic-, and Austronesian-language speaking populations in South and Southeast Asia than is generally assumed, and cries out for further research.

5.3 On Monstruosity, Mockery, and Association with Animals

The Semai conceive Nkuu’ as a “brutal deity, emotionally incontinent and often himself subject to being tricked and mocked”, a “ludicrous monster” indeed, an “evil ferocious destroyer God... so grotesquely stupid, so much a prey to his own passions, as to be a figure of fun; He knows that, and is ashamed” (Dentan 2002a, pp. 161–62). Nkuu’ is violent and yet stupid: “His desire to hurt makes Him stupid; His stupidity makes him desire to hurt; in stories about him, wanting to hurt, He hurts Himself” (Dentan 2008, p. 70). The reference to the “hurting oneself” due to one’s own stupidity and incontinence finds a striking parallel in the stories about the origin of the architectural element of Kāla(mukha), which in Java and Bali was identified with Bhaṭṭāra Kāla—intended as either the demonic child of Śiva, or as a demonic hypostase of the same. According to a popular legend, Kāla, out of a permanently insatiable hunger—and at Śiva’s studious request, in order to save other living beings—devoured his own body, thereby leaving only his head.

The practice of mocking the ludicrous qualities of the Godhead among the Semai for apotropaic aims is a feature that merits a close comparison with Indic (Tantric) religions in both South and Southeast Asia. For instance, the wild and inopportune behaviour of Kāla is mocked during theatrical performances in Bali. The *Kāla Purāṇa* relates how the ever-hungry Kāla wanted to devour his brother Kumāra on account of the fact that he had been given by Śiva the right to eat all persons born on the day of his younger brother’s birth (Stephen 2002, pp. 67–71).

The story is still put on stage in Bali, in slightly different versions, in (comic) performances held during rites of passage. Rather than being just a source of entertainment, such parodic performances are regularly enacted for apotropaic aims—in fact, just to make the gods ashamed of their deviant or destructive behaviours, and reorient their demonic nature towards their divine (benign) original form. As Stephen (2002, pp. 77–79) argues:

The significance of *wayan* performances and other entertainments as the means of causing Durgā and Kāla Rudra to return to their positive forms of Śiwa and Umā... seems to me an idea worthy of considerably more attention than has previously been given it... Kāla Rudra and Durgā were publicly shamed and their actions parodied in song, dance and *wayan* theatre.... Why? Because parody and humour are used to point to the evil doings of the god and goddess. There is no power that can control Śiwa and Umā in their terrible forms, only they can choose to transform themselves, but ridicule and laughter can cause shame and thus bring the pair to self-awareness.

Wayang performances of the legend of the birth of Kāla are also conducted in Java by *dalangs* for “exorcistic” and purificatory purposes (Headley 2004, pp. 321, 330).

The grotesque aspect of the Divine, embodied in a demonic trickster, is evident in an enigmatic passage of the Old/Middle Javanese text *Navaruci* (Prijoetomo 1934, p. 110). Having described the invisible and formless aspect of the Lord (*bhaṭāra* = Śiva), Devaruci reveals to the hero Bhīma the characteristics of one of His embodiments:

[... The Lord] becomes a human being; He becomes a male, He becomes a female; He becomes a four-legged animal, moving on all fours, His belly facing down.... He is skilled in singing and reciting. He knows to perform yoga and absorption. He is endowed with Gnosis and Power, there is nobody who equals Him. As for what constitutes His food, He pays little attention to what He eats: He eats his own body, He drinks his own blood.... He is not beautiful; He really likes to laugh. His manner of haughty speaking is not pleasant. [Being only] supernaturally mighty, He is in trouble with the discernment of the sacred scriptures.

The character described in the passage is indeed Bhīma himself, who shares many features with Kāla-Bhairava, the demonic aspect of the Lord Śiva. Bhīma combines features of Bhairava (both meaning: “the frightful one”) with those of the Pāṇḍava hero Bhīma—a mighty, and often wrathful and impulsive, warrior of gigantic proportions, whose strong point is almost uniquely his physical strength; in both the Sanskrit and Javanese versions of the *Mahābhārata* he is known as *vṛkodara*, “wolf-bellied”, because of his wild character and insatiable appetite.⁴⁷ The other features of this divine figure mentioned there, such as the ability to dance and recite, his violent laughter, his possession of Power (*śakti*), are all consonant with those attributed to Bhīma/Bhairava. The references to Bhīma as paying no attention to his diet, and especially as eating his own body and drinking his own blood, call to mind the myth of Kāla discussed above, and, on a human level, the dietary habits of Śaiva practitioners and the notorious practice of cannibalism and blood-drinking attributed to the Kāpālikas, the antinomian devotees of Kāla-Bhairava. A focus on performance and mockery can be also found among the Kāpālikas and their female attendants, the Kapālinīs or Yoginīs. These practitioners aimed at achieving a direct connection with their elected deity, the male Bhairava and/or various terrifying hypostases of the Goddess, through their observance of mimicking or taking upon themselves some of their elected deity’s features in order to reach a complete identification with it, i.e. be “penetrated” or possessed (*āveśa*) in a trance-like state, often triggered by frantic dances and transgressive behaviours. As pointed out by Dentan (2002a, p. 164), the Semai know the analogous concept of “loss of self” in both sexual and divine unions, which they call *asyik* (an Arabic loanword acquired via Malay).

⁴⁷ The “comparisons of Bhīma to wild animals (including lions, tigers and elephants), which are frequently made in the epic, show that he is considered wild, barbaric, demonic and almost animal-like. In Pampa’s tenth-century Kannada work *Bhārata*, Bhīma not only slays Duṣṣāsana but also drinks his blood and eats his flesh” (Bühnemann 2015, p. 470).

FIGURE 3.3



Relief Identified by Acri and Jordaan (2012) as Portraying the Directional Deity Kāla and His Entourage at Candi Siva, Loro Jonggrang Complex (Prambanan, Central Java), Ninth Century

Source: Courtesy of Mark Long.

The similarities between Nkuu’ and Kāla-Bhairava extend further. For instance, the Semai classify Nkuu’ as a giant red, black, or black and white ape. His younger brother is Pnoos, “Wind” (Dentan 2008, p. 70). Intriguingly enough, we find an association between Kāla-Bhairava, a monkey, and wind in the Indic imaginary. Kāla-Bhairava (alias Bhīma) is the brother of Hanumān, the mighty (and tricksterish) monkey-deity; Hanumān himself is regarded, and worshiped, as a manifestation of Bhairava in both South Asia and the Javano-Balinese world. In the Balinese *Kapiparwa* it is Hanumān who eats the Sun instead of his brother Kāla, as another popular Indic version of the story has it (see Vickers 2011, p. 127). East Javanese iconography of Hanumān (e.g. the reliefs of Candi Jago) is consonant with the iconography of Bhīma/Bhairava, as both characters share demonic and gigantic traits, a tricksterish nature, supernatural power, a connection with clouds and thunder, and a chequered, black-and-white loincloth (see Kieven 2011, pp. 222–23; Vickers 2011, p. 127). According to a widespread tradition, both Kāla-Bhairava/Bhīma and his brother Hanumān are the children of the (Vedic) god Vāyu/Bāyu and therefore share the appellative *bāyuputra* (“son of Wind”); furthermore, they are characterized by common iconographic features.⁴⁸ In the ninth-century temple-complex of Loro Jonggrang at Prambanan, a relief of Caṇḍi Śiva (Figure 3.3) displays a directional deity that Aciri and Jordaan (2012, pp. 301–2) have identified as Kāla on the basis of the Sanskrit-Old Javanese text *Bhuvanasaṅkṣepa*, which apparently inform the iconographical masterplan of the monument. A human-sized, fanged monkey is part of his entourage; the cloud right above the monkey’s head is evidently a symbolic pictorial representation of the wind, i.e. the atmospheric god Vāyu—the storm-god often equated to Rudra and Bhairava (both partaking of the root *ru*,

⁴⁸ When discussing the Balinese *Kapiparwa*, Vickers (2011, p. 127) notes that “[t]he link to Bayu explains a connection... which is otherwise mysterious.... They both have the ‘prawn claw’ (*supit urang*) coiffure of the semi-divine heroes of the epics, and both wear very little clothing except for the chequered (*poleng*) loincloth. In Balinese ritual use these *poleng* cloths, as the union of opposites, represent power (*sakti*)”. Bayu is “iconographically identical to Bima, except that he has the aureole and what Forge refers to as a ‘god spot’”.

“to roar, howl”). It would thus appear as if the Indic and Javano-Balinese worlds developed a variant configuration—in terms of different family relationships—of the association between a terrible manifestation of the Lord, a monkey, and wind, which we find among the Semai.

As I have remarked throughout this chapter, Kāla/Bhairava, the demonic embodiment of Śiva, holds a prominent position in the Southeast Asian mediaeval Tantric pantheon of both Śaiva and Buddhist persuasion. Even in the Islamic period the Malays paid homage to Śiva in his sinister aspect of Kāla, the destroyer of life (Danaraj 1964, p. 9, Dentan 2008, p. 67). Śiva as Kāla is called upon in Kelantan’s invocation at a state séance, and cycle of five days and five parts of the day are assigned to him (who is placed in the second position after Mahādeva, and before Śrī, Brahmā, and Viṣṇu). Winstedt (1961, p. 34) posited an affinity between the Rudra-Śiva worshiped by the Bhils, Kols and Gonds tribals of India and the “Demon Raja” or “Spectre Huntsman”, whose cult was popular among rural Malays; according to Dentan (2008, p. 66), these deities “may also descend from ‘the Lord’, as Semai call their thundersquall God”.

The fascination with a Dark Lord attested among all social strata of Austroasiatic- and Austronesian-speaking communities of the Indonesian and Malay world can hardly be explainable uniquely in terms of a (mediaeval) import of the prevailing South Asian/Sanskritic religious fashions. Conversely, to posit an Austroasiatic origin for the Rudra/Bhairava/Kāla complex, which has its roots in both Vedic and extra-Vedic milieux, would be equally misleading. To account for the widespread geographical diffusion and chronological resilience of this complex, one may perhaps regard it as a “convergent development” stemming from deep-rooted cultural tropes sharing a common ancestry across Monsoon Asia.

6. “Disreputable Magicians”: On Shamans and Yogins

There seems to be a connection between what Dentan calls “terrorist gods” and fringe socio-religious phenomena that scholars have tended to define as “shamanistic” in Semai, Vedic, and Tantric lore. For instance, the sinister Vedic thunder god Rudra was worshipped by

the *Vrātyas*, a class of “shamans” who “seem to have been outside the normal Aryan scheme of things” and may represent “survivors of some non-Aryan ascetic fraternity that was later loosely associated with the Brahmanic religion” (Basham and Zysk 1989, p. 16; cf. p. 58). The enigmatic *vrātyas* were “organized bands of young, celibate warrior ascetics living on the edges of vedic society.... It is not altogether unlikely that their livelihood advanced and influenced the development of the god’s cultic worship” (Bisschop 2013). Later counterparts of the *Vrātyas* were the *Pāśupatas* who, although belonging to the Brahmanical class, sought to achieve unity with Rudra by identifying with him through the antisocial (and impure) behaviours of “outsiders”; Ingalls (1962) argued that some of their observances, including babbling, making animal noises, and inopportune jokes, are remindful of those carried out by shamans.⁴⁹

As noted by Weber (1967, p. 295), outside of the Brahmanical order there was a “scorned substratum of disreputable magicians preoccupied with the problem of folk religiosity”—and, I would add, with the quest of supernatural powers (*siddhi*). Indeed, in many Asian contexts throughout the mediaeval period we find a wide array of marginal, non-Brahmanical practitioners who played the roles of paripatetic ascetics, performers, healers, astrologers, magicians, mediums, and exorcists. The South Asian regional instantiations of those practitioners-cum-ritual agents are known under a variety of names—e.g. *Ojhas* in Uttar Pradesh, *Baigas* in Madhya Pradesh, *Bhopas* in Rajasthan, etc.—, but have also been included in the broad category of “*Siddha*” (White 1996; Davidson 2002; Samuel 2006). A discussion of these figures may be relevant to the—still very much open—question of the transfer of religious and cultural ideas outside the Indian Subcontinent, across Monsoon Asia indeed, by agents other than the elite carriers of

⁴⁹ Subsequent Indological scholarship has abandoned this view, pointing out that the acts of *Pāśupata* adepts were not, as in the case of the shaman, manifestations of supernatural powers meant to cut them off from society, but rather aimed at provoking the contempt of others and thus gain good karma on the basis of a complex mechanism of transfer of merit (Lorenzen 1991, p. 188).

high culture, such as Hindu/Brahmanical or Buddhist religious/ritual specialists.

Dentan (2002a, p. 166) describes a class of Semai practitioners who observed dietary restrictions to placate their demonic wives (from whom they obtain supernatural power). Furthermore, there is a relationship between those practitioners and the tricksterish figure of Nkuu' (and the vicious supernatural beings associated with him), whose "power, which demons manifest, is the power to hurt, sicken and terrorize" (ibid., p. 164). This peculiar relationship reminds us of the relationship between what White (2009, p. 105) calls a "sinister yogin" and his elected deity, Bhairava:

The yogin is, in popular South Asian traditions, *none other than the bogey-man or the stock figure of the villain, the terrifying outsider who penetrates sleeping villages under the cover of night to carry off naughty children or unprotected village women*. This, I would argue is the most perennial and pervasive understanding of the person/a of the yogin in South Asia: not a meditating sage absorbed in quietistic introspection, but rather, a *powerful, terrifying Bhairava-like figure who penetrates the cosms of other people bodies, villages, citadels, and armies to conquer his own death by taking the lives of others*. (emphasis mine)

The yogin, like the shaman, literally enters and possesses others' bodies (*paraśarīrapraveśa*)—including those of animals. The class of yogins of the Kaula and Kāpālīka type carried out transgressive practices in order to be "entered" (*āveśa*) by Bhairava, their elected deity. Samuel (2006, p. 26) argues:

The key image in these practices is a male figure of magical power and control, a tantric sorcerer surrounded by a circle of fierce female deities. The magician, who takes on the role of a fierce deity associated with the god Śiva, masters and controls these female spirits. Through this mastery, he gains power over the elements and the cosmos, and is able to wield destructive magic.

Various scholars have suggested that the invocation of fierce female deities in magical rituals seems to stem from tribal milieux in mediaeval Indic society. According to Davidson (2002, p. 181), key Tantric temples

devoted to the cults and rituals associated with Yoginīs were “located in areas dominated by tribal peoples that were involved in sanguinary rituals”, which suggests that these sites “were constructed with a similar ritual in mind”, and were tribal before they became Hinduized (Urban 2011, p. 245).

Davidson (2002, p. 227) speaks of a convergence existing between the shaman and the Tantric Buddhist master, or the Śaiva/Buddhist wandering Siddha. This idea is not new: already in 1905, Oldenberg implied an analogous convergence between Vedic and tribal ritualists by declaring that we would have rightly understood *dīkṣā*, the dedicatory rite for him who wishes to celebrate the great Soma sacrifice,

if we compare the performer, hungry and sleepless, uttering stammering words, covered with an antelope’s skin and sitting near the magical fire which scares away demons, with the savage magic-priest, a well-known ethnological figure who seeks to secure mastery over evil spirits by mortification of the flesh.

Oldenberg (1973, p. 52)

Winstedt, linking Malay shamans to Hindu Tantrism, also implied some sort of convergence: “Hinduism in tantric form fortified the Malay shaman by corroborating the efficacy of fasting and seclusion and confirming the notion that trances bring supernatural power” (1961, p. 28). To him, the propitiatory ceremony to purify the Malay state (*pūjā negeri*) by seance, dancing, and sacrifice, conducted by a male or female shaman, would be a relic of Śaktism (ibid., p. 153–54); the Malay and Javanese enthronement ceremonies, the use of regalia, and the attribution of certain posthumous titles, all “would appear to belong to a very early layer of civilization” (ibid., p. 157). Hooykaas (1964) defined the Balinese low-status priest called *Rṣi Bhujāṅga/Seṅguhu*⁵⁰ as “a Shaman but not a Sufi, a Śaiva, and a Vaiṣṇava”.

⁵⁰ This is a Śaiva, non-Brahmanical ritual specialist serving the rural population, who probably derived from the Javanese class of practitioners called *Rṣis*, who in their turn might have been descendants of Pāśupata ascetics (Sanderson 2003–4, p. 376).

Certain types of religious practitioners of premodern Java have been regarded by scholars as shamanic in nature. These peripatetic figures involved in public performances (dance, pantomime, *wayang*, masked dance, trance) appear to be connected to a complex of elements associated with forms of shamanism or mediumship, namely thunder, ominous birds, sorcery, supernatural powers, antinomian behaviours, and exorcism. Among such figures were the *vidus*, whom I have suggested to identify as Śaiva practitioners specialized in performance (Acri 2011, p. 63, 2014b). In Sargas 24 and 25 of the Old Javanese *Rāmāyaṇa kakavin* (ca. ninth century CE) they are satirically linked to a bird, *kuvon* or *manuk vidu* (“*vidu* bird”), namely the migratory black coucal. In a passage of the Old Javanese *Bhomāntaka* (70.1), the coucal’s loud voice is connected with thunderclaps. The stanza, using the imagery of a ceremony, allegorically depicts the sounds produced by thunder, birds, and bull-frogs, evoking the accompaniment of musical instruments during a frenzy dance.⁵¹

The word *vidu* denotes an “actor (dancer, singer, reciter, leader in a performance?)” (Zoetmulder 1982) as well as a religious practitioner and medium. Echoes of this figure and the practices connected with him can be found throughout Southeast Asia, from the Malay peninsula to the Philippines. Aichele (1969, p. 134) pointed out that the words *bidu* and *biduan* in Classical Malay and *buduo’n* in Cham denote a class of comic (shamanic) dancers and musicians; furthermore, he drew attention to the modern Buginese form *widu-widu*, meaning “to joke, to play about”, and the Tagalog *biro*, meaning “quirk,

⁵¹ In the Indic imaginary, frogs—like the cuckoos and coucals in Old Javanese literature—call upon rain (cf. *R̥g Veda* 7.103: “the frogs have raised their voice that the god of the rainstorm has inspired”); furthermore, croaking is compared to the religious chanting of priests (cf. *Rāmāyaṇa kakavin* 24.117, where frogs are disciples of the coot, who is the alter ego of a Pāśupata master). The association of the *kuvon*/*manuk vidu* with a call resembling the rumbling of a thunder is found in other Old Javanese passages, namely in the prose *Tantri Kamaṇḍaka* B and its cognate Kiduṇ versions *Tantri Kēḍiri* and *Tantri Dēmuṇ*. The former text narrates the story “cuckoo and waterbirds”, where the *kuvon* features under the *nomen omen* of Vākbajra “thunder-voice(d)” (p. 5). The *kuvon* has a *bajragīta* “song of thunder” and is able to chant in a beautiful way to accompany dance.

joke, jest” (the reduplicate form *pagbibiro* is attested in a passage of a text dealing with the practices of a magician).⁵² Robson (1983, p. 293), in agreement with his predecessor, related the term *vidu* to the Malay *bidu* and *biduan*, “a singer at a shamanistic séance” (according to Wilkinson’s Malay-English dictionary), and argued that the root was indigenous Javanese and not Sanskrit. He connected this figure to a practitioner wandering the countryside to perform a kind of drama linked to exorcism, ritual, and the deeds of ancestors (*ibid.*, p. 294).

A striking description of the *vidu* is found in stanza 112 of Sarga 24 of the *Rāmāyaṇa kakavin*: a black coucal is homologized to a *vidu*, who is in turn characterized—through the lenses of Indic social categories—as a low-ranking wandering performer, accused of deceit and criminal intents, and declared to be *guṇya* (“having manifold supernatural abilities”, “powerful”, “endowed with good qualities”, or: “a sorcerer”) and *saguna* (“possessing magical/supernatural powers”, or “fitting in all roles”, i.e. play-acting) (Acri 2011, p. 62; cf. below). The word *guṇya* is found in Indic tribal milieus, where it is connected with sorcery. In contemporary Orissa, Tantric practitioners are referred to as *guṇiā*: Keul (2013, p. 6) characterizes them as “local tantriks” connected to Yoginī-cults, cremation-ground offerings and healing practices; among the Baigas of Central India and the Santals of (South-) Eastern India, *gunia* means “sorcerer” (Koppers 1940–41, p. 770).⁵³ Rahmann (1959, p. 687) describes a type of Munda village-priest, the *marang* (great) *deora*, primarily a “witch-finder” who derives his powers (*gun*) from Mahadeo (Śiva); *gun* is connected to the name of the Baiga sorcerer, *gunia* (Koppers 1940–41, p. 770). The word *sa-guṇa* in *Rāmāyaṇa kakavin* 24.112, as per Aichele’s (1969, p. 154) translation,

⁵² On the association of bards with shamanism in the Philippines, see Revel, Gage and Railing 1998.

⁵³ According to one recent study (Kumar et al. 2009), the Baigas share two synonymous polymorphisms with a haplogroup specific to Australian Aborigines, and their later ancestors are believed to have spoken an Austroasiatic language (Elwin 1939, pp. 53–55). The Santals speak an Austroasiatic language, Santali.

is a reference to the ability of the black coucal alias *vidu* to “fit in all roles” (namely, play-acting)—more literally, “endowed with [the ability to assume] any quality”. As we have seen in the case of *guṇya*, *guṇa* is commonly used as a synonym of “supernatural powers” (*siddhi*) in both Sanskrit and Old Javanese sources; in the latter, it also means “magic?” (Zoetmulder 1982, p. 553), while in modern Indonesian *guna-guna* means “(black) magic”, “charm”, “magical formula”. Among the goals of Pāśupata ascetics there was the obtainment of the eight supernatural powers/wondrous qualities (*guṇa*) of Rudra-Śiva, one of which was *kāmarūpitva*, “the ability to assume any form at will”. In the South Indian farce *Mattavilāsa* (6, p. 2), a drunk Kāpālīka praises his Kapālīnī for having obtained a beautiful appearance through the supernatural ability to assume any form at will (*kāmarūpatā*). Koppers (1940–41, p. 766) reports that the Santals know of one Kamru (also: Kambru, Kamruk, or Kam), who was the first magician and teacher of witchcraft (Ojhaism); according to Bodding, “It seems natural to connect the word with Skr. *kāma*, and *kāmarūpa*, whether in its original meaning of ‘taking any shape at will, beautiful pleasing’, or as the name of a country, the western portion of Assam. This makes it possible to take it either as the name of a person so called, or as the name of a person from Kamrup” (quoted in *ibid.*). A class of Indian mendicant actors are called Bahrūpia, from Sanskrit *bahu* (“many”) + *rūpa* (“form”; *bāhurūpya* = “manifoldness”), as referring to the ability to act; at the same time, Bahrūpa is a name for the black, fanged Southern face of Śiva/Bhairava (Aghora). The Bahrūpia were known for impersonating gods, especially in their terrible forms (cf. the image of a female impersonator of the goddess Kālī in Napier 1986, p. 165), and to imitate the notes of animals (Russell 1916, p. 344).

Other elements in the description of the *vidu*/black coucal in the *Rāmāyaṇa kakavin* seem to point to a Tantric milieu. For instance, in 24.114 the *kuvōṇ* invites a she-*kuvōṇ* to become a female ascetic (*kili*) and bring satisfaction to naked wandering ascetics (*kalavan lagnāmutusana*), thereby becoming an object of enjoyment (*bhukti*) for the devotees (*bhakta*) in the forest, who have lower-ranking wives

(*kula-kula*).⁵⁴ There is the possibility that (*ma-*)*kula-kula* may be a pun, meaning “having *kulas*” (= “gathering in clans”), implying a reference to the Sanskrit word *kula* in the sense of secret clans or families of initiated devotees, Yoginīs, and minor goddesses around which revolved the theology and ritual practice of the Tantric texts of the Kaula stream—themselves probably derived from an earlier Kāpālīka milieu. Samuel (2006, p. 26), when discussing Kāpālīka-related practices, refers to

the widespread role of low-caste ritual specialists in relation to kingship and political power, a pattern that has been identified in early Tamil literature and occurs in different forms in many parts of South Asia and the Himalayas. If fierce deity practices were originally performed by such low-caste specialists, then the *kula*, ‘families,’ of early tantric practice may derive from the families who carried them out.

Intriguingly enough, the same relationship between low-status ritual specialists and political power applies to the Javanese characters of the *vidu* and *pirus* (see Acri 2014b).

The association between the *vidu* and *pirus* performing characters and birds in various Old Javanese sources is significant. The black coucal (alias *vidu*) is an ominous bird in Javanese lore; coucals, as well as (black) crows and yellow wild pigeons (alias *pirus*) are taboo in both Semai and Old Javano-Balinese lore. In the Old Javanese manual for Śaiva priests *Ṛṣiśāsana*, these birds are mentioned as *krūrapakṣi* (“fierce/wild/bloody/terrifying birds”), whose meat is forbidden food for practitioners of the mainstream Śaiva Siddhānta. Indeed in the Sanskritic imaginaire, black birds, such as crows, and scavengers in general, were associated with Tantric practitioners (Zeiler 2013). Among the Semai, coucals as well as several yellow and black birds (such as crows), are *trlaac*-birds, i.e. connected with any action that might bring on violent disruption; other birds are “wives of thunder” (Dentan 2006, p. 298), or the evil offspring of the Dark Lord, the *ceep caas ʼseic* “flesh-eater birds”.

⁵⁴ Zoetmulder 1982, p. 914 s.v. *kula* II, *kula-kula*: “prob.: wife of lower rank, second wife to the queen (= *matur*, q.v.?)”.

Some premodern Javanese performing characters evoke tantalizing resonances with the figures of Kāpālīka, Kaula, and Siddha practitioners described in South Asian Sanskrit texts on the one hand, and with the mediums and performers found among modern Indian tribals of the Munda-belt on the other. Are the Javanese characters to be regarded as the localized heirs to a category of mediaeval Indic practitioners who travelled from the Indian Subcontinent to Southeast Asia? Or, do they represent “shamanic” figures with an Indic (Tantric) overlay, who survived to the modern period among some small-scale societies across Monsoon Asia, and ultimately share common traits derived from the same ancestry? More comparative research is required in order to throw light on this fascinating issue.

7. Conclusion

In this chapter I have discussed some of the distributional and functional similarities individuated by Dentan between certain features (both primary and secondary) of Semai religion and Hinduism, and argued that they extend beyond the Vedic period, being found in the religious systems prevalent in mediaeval South and Southeast Asia: Tantric Śaivism and Tantric Buddhism. The analyses of these similarities, and the hypotheses concerning their origin, give rise to a series of four possible positions and outcomes, either (or combinations) of which must be true:

- 1) The similarities are only alleged, i.e. they are the result of a fallacious methodology, wrong perception, or biased judgement by the investigator(s). In reality, no relationship exist between the religious tropes of (Tantric) Hinduism and Semai lore, and/or Sanskrit and Semai language.
- 2) The similarities exist, but they are not attributable to common origins and historical diffusion; on the contrary, they are merely coincidental, due to [a] pure chance; [b] analogous sociocultural responses/reactions to similar environmental stimuli (i.e. independent invention); or [c] a psychological or neuro-cognitive framework that is common to all mankind (i.e., human universals). This scenario implies what may be described as a

form of “weak convergence theory” (according to Wittgenstein’s concept of family resemblances, see Landmann, this volume), presupposing independent invention and development that is due to neither direct transfer nor indirect borrowing or influence (e.g. through a common genitor).

- 3) The similarities exist, and are due to a process of diffusion from an original source (or “giver”) to a “receiver”. Thus, it may be the case that [a] South Asian carriers of Sanskritic culture were the sources of Indic traits, and Austroasiatic- and Austronesian-speaking members of Indicized/Sanskritized Southeast Asian societies were the receivers; or [b] Southeast Asian agents were the sources of the “adstratal” cultural and linguistic traits borrowed by South Asian individuals. The first model would fit a “strong orthogenetic approach” in the study of Indian/Indic religions, which maintains that the origin of Hinduism and Tantrism are to be sought (exclusively) in a Vedic/Brahmanical milieu within the Indian Subcontinent; in such context, “tribals” of outlying areas were influenced by Sanskritic, Brahmanical, and/or Tantric traditions since the beginning of the early mediaeval period. The second model would fit an heterogenetic approach championing the opposite scenario, whereby the origin of “Classical Hinduism” and Tantrism is to be sought in an extra-Vedic context, which could have originated in South(east) Asian tribals contexts—possibly at an early historical period. Of course, the simultaneous occurrence of both processes is possible: as noted by Dentan (2002a, p. 171) with respect to the religion of the Semai, some Sanskrit words and Indic features were borrowed and “localized”, yet they retained a secondary role in their religious system, implying that a different wave of Sanskritization might have taken place.⁵⁵ In either cases, the

⁵⁵ Cf. Benjamin (2014, p. 274) who, while admitting that component elements derived from Brahmanical religions formed part of the practices of non-metropolitan communities in the Malay peninsula, asserts that “Brahminism as a functioning religious system did not spread far beyond the boundaries of Indianised settlements... neither the Malays nor the Semang could be said to have been Brahminists in any overall sense”.

similar traits would derive from early historical contacts between South and Southeast Asian people, and would have undergone an analogous process of localization on both sides of the Bay of Bengal.

- 4) The similarities exist, and represent parallel developments out of a common source—a cultural matrix extending across South Asia, Southeast Asia, and perhaps even into Southern China. I should like to stress that this cultural matrix is not an *echt*, essence or substratum, but rather a dynamic process—the result of centuries of circulation of people, languages and ideas—involving exchange, negotiation, and adaptation. It needs not have been homogeneous in its main traits; rather, it may have partaken of a plural set of “cultural packages” carried by multiple ethnic and linguistic groups (i.e. Austroasiatic- and Austronesian-speaking people). This paradigm represents a sort of “strong convergence theory”, which envisages the diffusion, filiation and localization of cultural and linguistic elements that developed across Monsoon Asia in parallel, as it were, and with cross-contaminations, out of a shared matrix. This shared matrix, which is earlier than the first attestations of written documents, may be only inferred by comparing, by means of a polythetic approach and family resemblances, the traits existing among modern purported “survivors” (such as the Semai, or Munda tribals), premodern textual corpora, and other historical datas from geographically distant (yet culturally related) contexts across Monsoon Asia.

I leave it to my readers to judge the likelihood of position 1. Position 2 and each of its subsets cannot be entirely dismissed; yet, the linguistic (diffusional) evidence and the documented historical links existing among many cultures across Monsoon Asia makes it improbable that all or most similarities are due to unrelated, independent developments.⁵⁶ For instance, we are not comparing randomly picked heterogeneous features in a de-contextualized fashion (think, for example, about the occurrence

⁵⁶ Blench (2013, p. 8) ironically points out that, whereas diffusionist approaches are now being generally regarded as outmoded in ethnography, “for some reason archaeologists do not generally use this argument [i.e. independent invention] for pottery”.

of a "thunder complex" among Indo-Europeans, Southeast Asians, and Amerindians), but a constellation of cultural tropes and linguistic features found within a geographical context with a long history of human interaction. As noted by Blust (1991, p. 518) with reference to the "thunder complex" in Australasia, "the explanation of the psychological or cultural dynamics of a coherent unit of culture... is distinct from the explanation of its distribution across culture".⁵⁷ What I am suggesting here is the possibility of historical contacts that enabled the multi-directional distribution and adoption of certain tropes—such as a "Dark Lord complex"—across Monsoon Asia. Some of the tropes detected by Dentan among the Semai would have been carried by Austroasiatic-speaking Negritos and incorporated into the religion, mythology, and languages of Austronesian-speaking people during their ever-expanding migrations across Southeast Asia and the Pacific, therefore becoming part of their cultural heritage; comparable dynamics could have happened on the opposite shore of the Bay of Bengal. A similar argument has been advanced by Blench (2013) regarding the arc of vegeculture and its cultural correlates stretching between Melanesia and eastern Nepal; by Gupta (2005, p. 22) regarding the distributions of jar burials along the Indo-Pacific arc, suggesting "the possibility of interactivity and sharing of otherworldly precepts from East Asia to South Asia"; and by Manguin (1996, p. 191), who speaks about "a fair amount of interchange and cross-fertilization, if not of homogeneity in technical traditions" across the western and eastern shores of the Bay of Bengal. Brighenti's (2009, p. 63) arguments concerning the South

⁵⁷ Blust (1991) characterizes the "thunder complex" as one of the most distinctive and widespread ethnological markers known in Southeast Asia. This cultural complex, which is focally concerned with the belief that mockery of animals will precipitate a punitive thunderstorm entailing some type of physical transformation of the offender, is known among the Semai and many other tribal societies in the Philippines, Borneo and Eastern Indonesia. According to Blust (*ibid.*, p. 517), even though "nativized and augmented with features it probably did not have in its original form", this complex could still be traced back "to a prehistoric society which was ancestral not only to the modern Austronesian-speaking societies of western and eastern Indonesia, but also to those of Oceania". A wider discussion of linguistic and cultural features supporting a common Negrito ancestry across Southeast Asia may be found in Blust 2013.

Asian Tantric instantiations of human sacrifice are directly relevant to the present discussion, positing as they do that “continuous interchange of socioreligious customs and of mythical, doctrinal, and ritual elements relating to human sacrifice has taken place since protohistoric epochs in the Indian subcontinent”, and had as its vectors the “people of the Veda” as well as people of disparate ethnic origins and linguistic background (viz. Dravidian, Austroasiatic, Austronesian, and Tibeto-Burman).

On the basis of the quantitatively scant, but qualitatively significant, cumulative evidence presented in this chapter, I consider positions 3 and 4 the most likely. These hypotheses are not mutually exclusive, as they do not preclude the occurrence of two-way contacts. In the specific, one may hypothesize that a certain ideology or mythologeme might have returned to its place of origin after centuries of independent development in an outlying geographic and cultural context (compare Witzel’s “imagined investigation” quoted above). This model, along with the “Monsoon Asian shared cultural matrix”, could help explain why certain ideas and practices that once existed in the Indian Subcontinent could so easily be revived or connected with those still found in other parts of the Indic world, namely mainland and insular Southeast Asia. In short, the fundamental affinity between cultural traits/trajectories in South and Southeast Asia would be due to historical processes of multi-directional interaction, transfer, and filiation, which could have taken place in the context of an interconnected geo-environmental area. More importantly, the continuous presence in the Indian Subcontinent of Austroasiatic-speaking people, who most likely shared an early core of socio-cultural features with their “cousins” in Southeast Asia, suggests that these contacts and transfers are not a mere theoretical possibility. The attestation of Sanskrit loanwords among the South and Southeast Asian tribals and, concomitantly, of Austroasiatic loanwords in Sanskrit and Middle Indo-Aryan languages, further supports this scenario of long-standing historical connections. These connections, inferred on the basis of recent archaeological findings, have been described by Manguin as a “millenium-long phase of exchange” (2011, p. xvi) that predates the beginnings of “Indianization” in the third–fifth centuries CE, when “the relationship between Southeast Asian and Indian societies had already come a very long way” (ibid., p. xix).

Whatever the case may be, this chapter makes a case to de-parochialize the study of Indic religions, so as to transcend the intellectual and geopolitical boundaries that, unduly compartmentalizing this cross-cultural subject of enquiry, hamper our understanding of the larger picture. I cannot but side with Samuel who, noting the "arbitrary nature of regional traditions of intellectual inquiry", calls for a change of perspective in trying to look at Tibeto-Burman-speaking societies of Tibet, Ladakh, Nepal and Sikkim as part of Southeast Asia rather than Central or South Asia—the rationale being that the Tibeto-Burman linguistic family has been biased towards South and Central Asia, yet Eastern India belongs culturally more to Southeast Asia than South Asia (2005, pp. 199–200).⁵⁸ Warning us not to confuse analytic categories with reality, and expressing the need to "move beyond the parochial concerns to which it... has so often been restricted", Samuel (*ibid.*, p. 208) points out that

Frameworks to which Tibetanists have become attached for historical reasons are not necessarily the most appropriate, and that the kind of shift in perspective which I have described may be a valuable supplement and corrective to our established practices.

In a similar fashion, in his analysis of the "Demonological Cosmopolis", White (2012, pp. 164–65) recognizes that

While it remains useful to speak of regional or local traditions (Bengali Tantra, for example), it is totally inappropriate to assume that translocal traditions conform to modern geopolitical maps of the Indian subcontinent. Hindu Tantra is 'Indic' only to the extent that KGB [i.e. Kashmir, Gandhara, and Bactria], Nepal, and even the Tarim Basin are parts of India, which they are not.

Analogous considerations could be extended to Southeast Asia and its "Indic" religions. As Samuel (2011, p. 348) notes when discussing the theoretical framework of his monograph *The Origins of Yoga and Tantra* (2008),

⁵⁸ A similar argument was advanced by Kunstandter (1967, p. 205), who included Eastern India in Southeast Asia on account of linguistic and cultural similarities: "Just as the southern boundary of China does not mark a cultural or linguistic division, the eastern border of India does not mark off a cultural or linguistic area".

India as we know it today is a very recent entity. It is all too easy to think of the development of ‘Hinduism’ or at least of ‘Indian religions’ as a process that took place within a territory called ‘India’ and which corresponds roughly to present-day India or even to the rather problematic wider region called ‘South Asia’ for purposes of Western academia.... I deliberately worked Southeast Asia into the account throughout the book, in part to stress that the adoption of Brāhmanical religion was an ongoing process and that Cambodia was in much the same position in relation to this process, if at a slightly later date, than Bengal or South India. It is important to understand these processes within a *common frame*. The fact that we now have an India that is mainly Hindu and a Southeast Asia that is Buddhist, Muslim and so on is a much later development, and we need to think back to a *quite different sort of geography* to make sense of these earlier periods. *This is not a dramatically new thing to say, but the consequences of working it into the account was to bring up some issues that had not been raised so clearly by many previous authors.* (emphasis mine)

Key concepts here are the “common frame”, and the “quite different sort of geography”, which Samuel invokes to make sense of the complex religious and cross-cultural processes that occurred over an extended period of time throughout a large swathe of continental and maritime Asia. I would add a “quite different sort of history” too, which would help us to make sense of phenomena whose roots lie in a remote past, i.e. an older core of religious beliefs, practices, and mythologies that is difficult to reconstruct given the scantness of the records that have survived the ravages of time. I believe, however, that the lack of textual and archaeological evidence should not deter scholars from elaborating wider-ranging narratives that include a remote past to explain premodern and modern phenomena on the basis of data analysed from the perspective of comparative mythology and religion, historical linguistics, and with insights from modern and contemporary ethnography. More research on the small-scale societies of South and Southeast Asia and their historical interactions with Sanskritic ideologies and Indic cosmopolitan societies is needed to test Dentan’s provocative hypothesis.

To date, the prevalent attitude among contemporary Indologists towards the manifestations of Indic religions and cultural traits in

Southeast Asia has not gone beyond the uncritical subscription to a monodirectional “Hinduization” paradigm; on the other hand, the majority of Southeast Asianists has tended to favour an “indigenistic” paradigm, stressing Southeast Asian agency in the “localization” of Indic ideas and practices. Concomitantly, Indologists have predilected an orthogenetic paradigm to explain the emergence of the phenomenon of Tantrism in South Asia from a (late) Vedic matrix. On the other hand, as rightly noted by Brighenti (2009, p. 95), to explain the various stages of the process of tribal-Śākta interactions in the Indian Subcontinent we “may necessitate moving beyond the ancient limits of Vedic India”. In fact, one may even include the Vedic “antecedents” of Tantrism in a wider-ranging analysis that approaches the study of Indic religions “from the East”, so to speak, as partaking of a shared cultural matrix out of which parallel developments originated across the Bay of Bengal and South China Sea, in the context of a millenia-long shared history. In order to do so, it would perhaps be appropriate to revive, and refine, the “Monsoon Asia perspective” elaborated by early twentieth century scholarship. By extending the field of study to the wider geo-environmental area of Monsoon Asia, the synthesis advocated here would regard seemingly convergent religious and cultural phenomena as the outcome of multi-directional and circulatory processes rather than separate, self-contained entities, and propose a possible shared ancestry.

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